"What Were They Thinking?" Using Open-Text Responses to Validate Constructs in Survey Experiments

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Abstract

Conjoint experiments rest on an assumption that is rarely tested: that respondents reason about profile attributes in the way the construct of interest specifies. Open-text questions, familiar as basic manipulation checks, can do much more. I argue they should be taken seriously as evidence about construct validity and experimental design, and I develop a framework that combines structural topic modeling (STM) for unsupervised discovery with large language model (LLM) classification for theory-driven confirmation. I apply the framework across three conjoint experiments. In a conjoint on immigrant naturalization in South Korea and Taiwan, a social integration cue shifts respondent reasoning from economic and practical criteria toward civic engagement; STM and LLM classification converge on this finding. A second conjoint on immigrant admission shows the framework transfers to designs without within-attribute randomization and refines constructs an earlier analysis grouped too coarsely. A third conjoint on North Korean migrant entrepreneurship benchmarks LLM performance against expert human-coded ground truth and confirms that iterative codebook refinement raises LLM-human agreement. Token-level log-probabilities measure model uncertainty, a calibration approach uncommon in survey text-as-data work; they predict when models disagree and reveal that all models are overconfident relative to human coding.

Keywords: survey experiments, construct validation, open-ended questions, structural topic models, large language models, text classification, immigration attitudes

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Introduction

Conjoint experiments are the most widely used survey design in contemporary political science (Hainmueller et al., 2014). Respondents evaluate multi-attribute profiles and make forced choices, producing average marginal component effects (AMCEs) for each attribute. But conjoint designs carry an untested assumption: that respondents reason about profile attributes in the way the construct of interest specifies, and that closed-ended response items capture that reasoning. A conjoint profile may contain ten or more randomly varied attributes, yet researchers typically interpret treatment effects as if respondents attended to and processed each attribute independently. The possibility that respondents focused on entirely different aspects of the profile, or interpreted attributes in unexpected ways, is rarely examined directly.

I propose embedding open-text questions in conjoint experiments and using computational text analysis to examine respondent reasoning directly. When a respondent is asked "Why did you choose this person?" after a conjoint task, the answer reveals the reasoning behind the observed choice. Open-text responses are already familiar as basic manipulation checks, verifying that respondents noticed or encoded an experimental stimulus (Ziegler, 2022). My claim is stronger: open-text responses should be used as direct evidence about whether the construct the researcher intends to measure is in fact the construct respondents reason about, and about whether the experimental design activates that reasoning. That is a question about construct validity and about the experimental design itself. Stimulus delivery is the simpler manipulation-check question. I demonstrate the approach across three conjoint surveys representing three validation scenarios: a primary conjoint with within-attribute treatment randomization (clean identification of how a cue shifts reasoning); a standard conjoint without within-attribute randomization (transfer to the more common design and retrospective construct refinement); and a conjoint with expert human-coded classifications (direct calibration against a trusted benchmark).

The analytical framework combines unsupervised and supervised text analysis. Structural topic modeling (STM) serves as a *discovery* tool, asking what topics respondents discuss and how experimental conditions affect topic prevalence (Roberts et al., 2014). Large language model (LLM) classification provides *confirmation*, asking whether open-text responses align with theory-derived categories following recent

codebook design frameworks (Halterman and Keith, 2025). A third layer takes advantage of what makes LLMs different from human coders. The existing literature treats LLM output as text, evaluating the model's classification label the same way it would evaluate a human coder's label (Törnberg, 2025; Heseltine and Clemm von Hohenberg, 2024; Chae and Davidson, 2025). But language models also produce a probability distribution over tokens at each generation step. Extracting the token-level log-probability (logprob) assigned to the classification label gives a measure of model uncertainty that is distinct from the self-reported confidence the model generates as text. I use these logprobs to assess whether the models are *calibrated*, that is, whether the predicted probability corresponds to actual classification accuracy.

The primary application uses conjoint survey data on immigrant naturalization in South Korea and Taiwan, collected in 2024 (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2015; Denney and Green, 2021). The conjoint includes a "social integration" attribute that randomly describes immigrants' civic engagement activities. The validation question is direct: when respondents see the social integration cue, do they write about civic engagement? They do. The cue increases civic reasoning by 7–18 percentage points while reducing economic and credential-based reasoning, across both methods and six LLM classifiers (Fleiss' $\kappa = 0.745$). The second application extends the framework to Denney and Green (2021), an earlier conjoint on immigrant admission preferences in South Korea. Because that design lacks within-attribute treatment randomization, it tests whether the framework transfers to the more common setup; it also shows that open-text evidence can decompose a construct that the original study grouped into a single broad category, refining measurement in a completed study. The third application turns to Denney et al. (2024), a conjoint on North Korean migrant entrepreneurship policy for which two trained human coders classified every open-text response. That dataset supplies the expert ground truth needed to calibrate LLM classifications directly, and it provides an independent test of whether the iterative codebook workflow produces meaningful gains in classification accuracy.

The contribution has four parts. First, I develop a two-stage workflow for construct validation in conjoint experiments: unsupervised topic modeling discovers the empirical structure of open-text responses, and those findings inform the design of a theory-driven codebook for LLM classification. Unlike approaches that apply LLM classification or scaling directly (Mellon et al., 2024; DiGiuseppe and Flynn,

2026), this workflow uses the unsupervised step to check and refine the codebook before classification begins. Second, I show that token-level log-probabilities provide a useful measure of classification uncertainty. These probabilities predict inter-rater agreement ($r_s = 0.46$) but also reveal that all six models are overconfident relative to human-coded ground truth (Expected Calibration Error 0.14–0.26), which means researchers should not take LLM confidence at face value. Third, all classification uses six models (one proprietary, five open-weight from 3B to 72B parameters) to test reproducibility across model families and sizes (Barrie et al., 2025; Chae and Davidson, 2025). Fourth, I extend LLM classification of open-text responses from theory-defined codes to stimulus-grounded attribute uptake. The model is given the same selected and unselected profile the respondent saw, and labels which displayed attribute the response invokes and how closely the language matches a specific level. This adds a complementary test of stimulus uptake on top of category-based coding, and the resulting measure is portable to any conjoint with open-text responses, including conjoints without within-attribute treatment randomization.

Background and Related Work

Open-Ended Questions in Survey Research

Open-ended questions have a long history in survey research, but their systematic use for construct validation is less established. Geer (1988) showed that open-ended responses capture genuine attitudes rather than mere articulateness. Lupia (2018) documented persistent quality problems in coding open-ended responses and called for greater transparency. Glazier et al. (2021) introduced a "self-coding" method where respondents categorize their own open-ended responses, a direct check on whether researcher-imposed categories match respondent interpretations. Ziegler (2022) uses text-as-data methods on open-ended survey responses as manipulation checks. Haaland et al. (2025) review the growing use of open-ended survey data to uncover mechanisms behind beliefs and behavior, including LLM-based annotation at scale.

This paper extends that line of work by using computational text analysis to scale from small hand-coded samples to entire survey populations.

Structural Topic Models

Topic models provide a data-driven approach to discovering the thematic structure of text corpora (see Grimmer and Stewart, 2013; Grimmer et al., 2022; Gentzkow et al., 2019).[1] Roberts et al. (2014) developed the Structural Topic Model for contexts where document-level metadata (such as experimental treatment conditions) should inform topic estimation; Roberts et al. (2016) provide the formal statistical foundation. Unlike standard LDA, STM allows covariates to affect both topic prevalence (which topics appear in which documents) and topic content (which words are associated with which topics). This makes STM ideal for survey experiments: researchers can directly estimate how experimental conditions affect the topics respondents discuss (see also Egami et al., 2022; Fong and Grimmer, 2023, on causal inference with text).

Hobbs and Green (2025) distinguish between topic discovery and attitude inference, arguing that topic models excel at the former but require careful interpretation for the latter. The present application is primarily concerned with topic discovery (identifying what respondents discussed) and with treatment effects on topic prevalence.

LLM-Based Text Classification

Large language models are now widely used for text classification (Gilardi et al., 2023; Ziems et al., 2024; Bail, 2024; Mellon et al., 2024; Rathje et al., 2024; Törnberg, 2025; Heseltine and Clemm von Hohenberg, 2024; Ornstein et al., 2025). Chae and Davidson (2025) show that model size and prompting strategy jointly determine classification quality, which the present study tests directly by deploying models from 3B to 72B parameters. Most work assigns each response to a discrete code; DiGiuseppe and Flynn (2026) instead place responses on a continuous scale via LLM pairwise comparisons and Bradley-Terry modeling. The present study asks what *kind* of reasoning respondents use, so categorical codes are the natural fit. Halterman and Keith (2025) argue that classification quality depends most on codebook precision (definitions, inclusion/exclusion criteria, worked examples) rather than on model choice.

Reproducibility is a separate concern. Barrie et al. (2025) show that proprietary LLM APIs exhibit

[1] For the foundational Latent Dirichlet Allocation model, see Blei et al. (2003).

substantial variance across runs and model versions, and recommend open-weight models with fixed parameters for deterministic outputs (see also Le Mens and Gallego, 2025). The present design responds to this: five open-weight models form the reproducible core, with GPT-4o-mini included as a reference point for the proprietary models that dominate current practice (Gilardi et al., 2023; Törnberg, 2025; Heseltine and Clemm von Hohenberg, 2024; Chae and Davidson, 2025).

Data and Research Design

Primary Application: Naturalization Conjoint

The primary data come from original surveys conducted in South Korea and Taiwan between January and June 2024, examining public attitudes toward immigrant naturalization. Respondents were recruited via Qualtrics using stratified quota sampling by sex, age, and geographic region; the final samples comprise $N = 1{,}999$ in South Korea and $N = 2{,}050$ in Taiwan. Each respondent evaluated paired immigrant profiles in a forced-choice conjoint (Hainmueller et al., 2014; Bansak et al., 2021), with profiles varying on 12 randomly assigned attributes (Supplementary Information, Table A.6). The attribute of interest is *social integration*, which describes the immigrant's civic engagement with four levels ranging from "only associates with fellow expatriates" to "volunteers weekly at a local community center." This attribute was randomly withheld from some profiles, creating a clean cue-shown vs. cue-not-shown comparison indexed by the treatment variable `cue_shown`. Shares are approximately balanced by design (South Korea: 49.8% cue-shown; Taiwan: 49.1%).

After the conjoint task, respondents answered an open-text question: *"Why did you choose this person as more deserving of citizenship?"* The corpus comprises 4,049 responses in Korean and Traditional Chinese. Responses are brief (median 6–10 characters) but substantive: approximately 79% receive a substantive code under majority-vote LLM classification, which means they contain identifiable references to profile attributes.

Secondary Applications

Two earlier conjoints extend the analysis. Denney and Green (2021) is a 2020 conjoint on immigrant admission in South Korea ($N = 1{,}008$) with seven attributes and no within-attribute randomization, which provides a test of whether the framework transfers to the more common conjoint setup and whether open-text evidence can refine constructs an earlier analysis grouped too coarsely. Denney et al. (2024) is a 2020 conjoint on South Korean attitudes toward North Korean migrant entrepreneurship policy ($N = 2{,}009$) for which two trained human coders independently classified every open-text response (inter-coder $\kappa = 0.881$), providing the expert benchmark needed to calibrate LLM classifications and to test whether iterative codebook refinement closes the gap between LLM and expert coding. Table 1 summarizes all three.

	Naturalization	**Admission**	**N.K. Entrepreneurship**
Country	South Korea, Taiwan	South Korea	South Korea
N (respondents)	4,049	1,008	2,009
Year	2024	2020	2020
Source	Original (this paper)	Denney and Green (2021)	Denney et al. (2024)
Topic	Immigrant citizenship	Immigrant admission	N.K. migrant business support
Treatment	Civic cue randomized	None (standard conjoint)	None (standard conjoint)
Open-text language	Korean, Traditional Chinese	Korean (+ English translation)	Korean (+ English translation)
Classification codes	5	5	4
Human ground truth	No	No	Yes (2 coders, $\kappa = 0.881$)
Role in paper	Primary analysis	Framework portability	Calibration & validation

Table 1: Three conjoint datasets used in this paper. Note: N.K. = North Korea.

Analytical Framework

Approach 1: Structural Topic Modeling

I fit separate STM models for each country, using the `stm` package in R (Roberts et al., 2019) with spectral initialization and seed = 42. Korean text is preprocessed using the `kiwipiepy` morphological analyzer and Chinese text using `quanteda`'s built-in segmenter (Benoit et al., 2018). Preprocessing follows established guidelines for multilingual text analysis (Lucas et al., 2015; Denny and Spirling, 2018).

Since the conjoint design is fully randomized, the prevalence specification includes only the treatment indicator:

$$\text{prevalence} \sim \texttt{cue_shown} \tag{1}$$

I select the number of topics (K) using the coherence-exclusivity tradeoff from `searchK()` diagnostics, resulting in $K = 6$ for South Korea and $K = 8$ for Taiwan.

Treatment effects on topic prevalence are estimated using `estimateEffect()`, which provides coefficient estimates, standard errors, and confidence intervals for the effect of `cue_shown` on each topic's prevalence.

Approach 2: LLM Classification

I developed the codebook iteratively, using STM findings to guide refinement. The initial version (v1) used four codes: `civic_commitment`, `identity_concern`, `economic_focus`, and `other`. The civic commitment code captured civic engagement, volunteering, and community involvement, but also included language competence and length of residence as signals of integration commitment.

Running v1 across GPT-4o-mini exposed a problem: 561 responses (13.9%) were coded as civic commitment based solely on language fluency or residence duration, which are practical integration attributes that do not in themselves indicate active civic engagement. The STM results showed that topics about language and residence *decrease* when the social integration cue is shown, meaning these attributes behave as substitutes for civic engagement. Including them under civic commitment conflated participation in

community life with individual-level adaptation to the host country.

This STM-informed diagnosis led to a revised codebook (v2) with five codes (a third revision, v3, was applied to the secondary N.K. data; see Section 7):

Code	Definition
`civic_commitment`	Participation in community life: volunteering, community organizing, social participation. Outward-facing, prosocial engagement
`functional_integration`	Individual-level adaptation: language competence, residence duration, law-abiding behavior. Practical prerequisites for functioning in the host country
`identity_concern`	Ethnic, cultural, or national identity concerns, including religion and ethnicity when used as evaluation criteria
`economic_focus`	Economic contributions: jobs, taxes, career, occupation, work experience
`other`	Truly uninformative responses: filler words, gibberish, meta-comments. Brevity alone is never a reason for this code

Table 2: LLM classification codebook (v2). Codes follow the design principles of Halterman and Keith (2025), with explicit definitions, inclusion/exclusion criteria, and few-shot examples in both Korean and Traditional Chinese.

The classification pipeline uses six LLMs. GPT-4o-mini (OpenAI API) provides a reference point for the proprietary models used in prior work. Five open-weight models form the reproducible core:

Model	Parameters	Infrastructure	Role
GPT-4o-mini	—	OpenAI API	Proprietary baseline; representative of models used in current practice
Qwen 2.5 3B	3B	Consumer GPU	Open-weight; smallest model
Llama 3.1 8B	8B	Consumer GPU	Open-weight; mid-range
Gemma 3 12B	12B	University HPC (A100)	Open-weight; mid-range
Qwen 2.5 32B	32B	University HPC (A100)	Open-weight; large
Qwen 2.5 72B	72B	University HPC (A100)	Open-weight; largest model; size scaling

Table 3: LLM classifiers used in the analysis. Open-weight models are run via the Ollama framework with temperature = 0 and seed = 42 for deterministic output.

All open-weight models are run with temperature = 0, seed = 42, and max_tokens = 200, producing deterministic outputs. GPT-4o-mini is run with the same parameters, but proprietary API outputs are not strictly reproducible across runs due to batched inference and silent model updates (Barrie et al., 2025). The open-weight models therefore provide the reproducibility guarantee; GPT-4o-mini serves as a reference point for the proprietary models that dominate current practice. The range of model sizes (3B to 72B parameters, including three from the Qwen 2.5 family) allows a direct test of whether classification quality scales with model size (Chae and Davidson, 2025). The classification prompt also asks each model to self-report a confidence level (HIGH, MEDIUM, or LOW). This is what researchers encounter in normal LLM interaction: the model generates a confidence label as text, producing what it judges a plausible human coder would report. But this self-assessed confidence is itself a generated token with no necessary relationship to the model's actual predictive uncertainty.

LLMs are text-prediction machines; this difference from human coders can be put to use. A language model generates text one token at a time, computing a probability distribution over its vocabulary at each step.[2] For each classification, I extract the logprob the model assigns to the first token of the classification label. This reflects the model's predictive distribution at the moment of classification, distinct from any self-assessment the model generates as text. The classification prompt concentrates over 99% of the probability mass on the five valid code prefixes for the typical response (SI Table **??**). SI Appendix C reports the full calibration analysis.

Implementation: codebook generation (from a structured YAML following Halterman and Keith 2025), cross-model validation, and statistical analyses are in R; the OpenAI classifier is a Python script. Open-weight models are deployed through Ollama with fixed inference parameters. The 3B and 8B models run on a consumer GPU (RTX 3060 Ti, 8GB VRAM); the 12B, 32B, and 72B models run on a university HPC cluster with A100 GPUs, with the 32B and 72B quantized to 4-bit. Full code and outputs are in the replication archive.

Each response is classified independently by all six models, treated as diverse raters (Benoit et al.,

[2] The log-probability (logprob) is the natural logarithm of the softmax probability assigned to a token. A token with probability 0.92 has 92% of the model's predictive mass; a token with probability 0.45 leaves substantial mass on competing alternatives.

2026). The majority-vote classification assigns each response the code that four or more of the six models agree on; responses without a four-model consensus (7.2%) are excluded. The primary estimand is the intent-to-treat (ITT) difference in code prevalence between `cue_shown` $= 1$ and `cue_shown` $= 0$ arms among all randomized respondents who provided a non-empty open-text response, with the `other` category retained in the denominator. Bootstrap confidence intervals (2,000 iterations, percentile method) provide inference. Per-model and substantive-codes-only secondary estimates appear in SI Tables C.8–C.9. Because the six models share pretraining data, the inter-model $\kappa = 0.745$ likely overstates what independent annotators would produce; the N.K. ground-truth extension ($\kappa \approx 0.6$–0.7) provides a more realistic lower bound. Majority-vote aggregation also reduces the influence of model-specific biases (e.g., Llama 3.1 8B's inflated functional integration rate in Taiwan).

The individual models produce consistent results even without aggregation: all six agree on the direction of every substantive effect, with civic commitment increasing between +9.4 and +18.1 pp across models and countries (SI Table C.8). Results are stable across alternative thresholds (3/6, 5/6) and when GPT-4o-mini is excluded entirely (SI Appendix F). A simple keyword/dictionary baseline detects the same treatment direction but attenuates the magnitude by half ($\kappa = 0.51$ with the LLM majority vote).

Combining the Two Approaches

The two methods answer different questions. STM shows the empirical structure of the text without imposing prior categories and can surface patterns the researcher did not anticipate, but it cannot tell you whether a topic corresponds to a specific theoretical construct. LLM classification maps responses onto theory-derived categories with greater precision, but only if the categories are right. The framework runs both. STM identifies empirical structure, LLM classification applies theoretical categories informed by that structure, and the combination catches codebook errors either method alone would miss. The civic-cue analysis is a worked example. STM showed language and residence topics moving *opposite* to civic engagement under treatment, which exposed a v1 codebook that grouped constructs responding differently to the manipulation, prompting the v2 revision before any inference was drawn. The methods produce different effect magnitudes for a structural reason. STM distributes noise across all topics

while LLM classification routes uninformative responses to `other`, producing a cleaner denominator for substantive codes. As diffusely assigned STM documents are excluded, the STM civic effect rises monotonically toward the LLM estimate (SI Appendix B).

Results

STM: What Did Respondents Write About?

The South Korean model ($K = 6$) identifies six topics that map onto conjoint profile attributes and respondent evaluation criteria. The largest topics concern identity and practical credentials: religious/ethnic preferences (23.3%), residence and assimilation effort (21.4%), and community engagement and volunteering (19.0%). Employment and family stability (12.7%), professional experience (11.9%), and language/visa considerations (11.7%) account for the rest. Taiwan's model ($K = 8$) produces a comparable structure, with work experience and social integration (18.7%), language fluency and first impressions (18.7%), and civic activities and ethnicity (14.6%) as the largest topics.

That respondents wrote about the attributes they saw in the immigrant profiles is itself a finding. It means they processed the experimental stimuli and evaluated candidates on the dimensions the conjoint design intended to test.

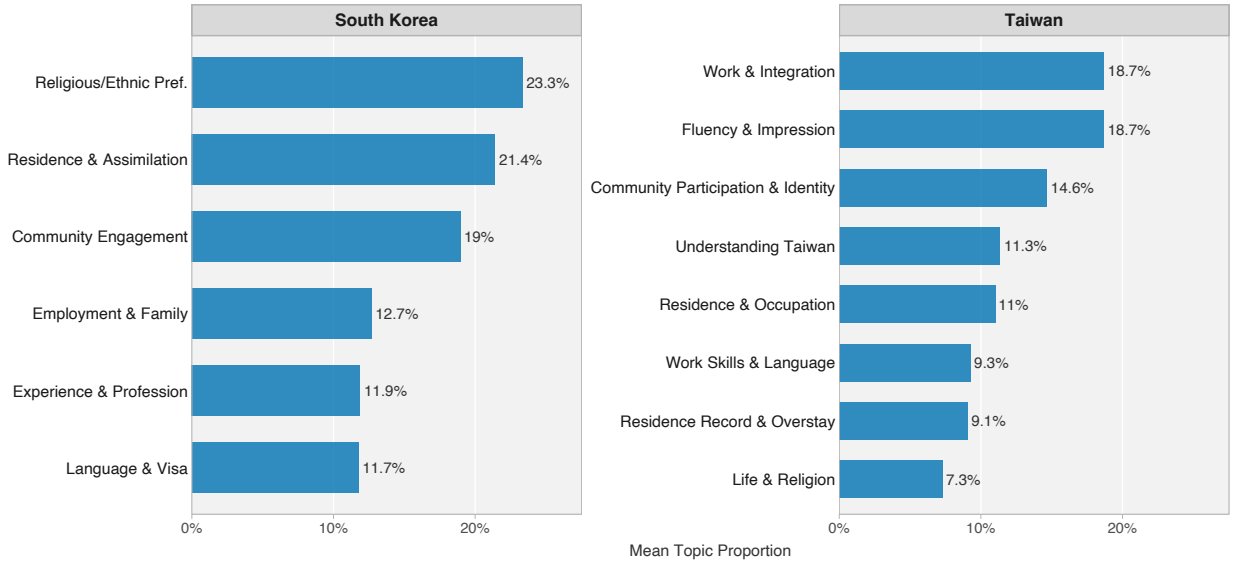

Figure 1: STM topic prevalence by country. Mean document-topic proportions for South Korea ($K = 6$, $N = 1{,}734$ STM-analyzable documents) and Taiwan ($K = 8$, $N = 1{,}905$).

STM: Effect of the Social Integration Cue

In South Korea, the social integration cue increases discussion of Community Engagement by 6.7 percentage points (pp) while decreasing discussion of Language & Visa (-4.0 pp) and Employment & Family (-2.3 pp). All three effects are statistically significant.

Taiwan shows the same pattern at greater magnitude. The cue increases Community Participation & Identity by 11.4 pp, Work & Integration by 3.1 pp, and Understanding Taiwan by 1.8 pp, while decreasing Fluency & Impression (-5.4 pp), Residence & Occupation (-4.7 pp), Residence Record (-3.0 pp), and Work Skills (-2.7 pp). All effects are significant at the 95% level; see Figure 2.

The pattern is consistent across both countries, and the *substitution* effects are as informative as the civic increase. If the open-text responses merely reflected attribute recall, respondents parroting back what they saw, one would expect the civic cue to add civic language without displacing other themes. Instead, language, residence, and employment topics all decline, suggesting that the cue reshapes the evaluative framework rather than adding a talking point. This substitution pattern is the strongest evidence that the social integration attribute affects how respondents reason about the profiles, beyond influencing what they choose to mention afterward.

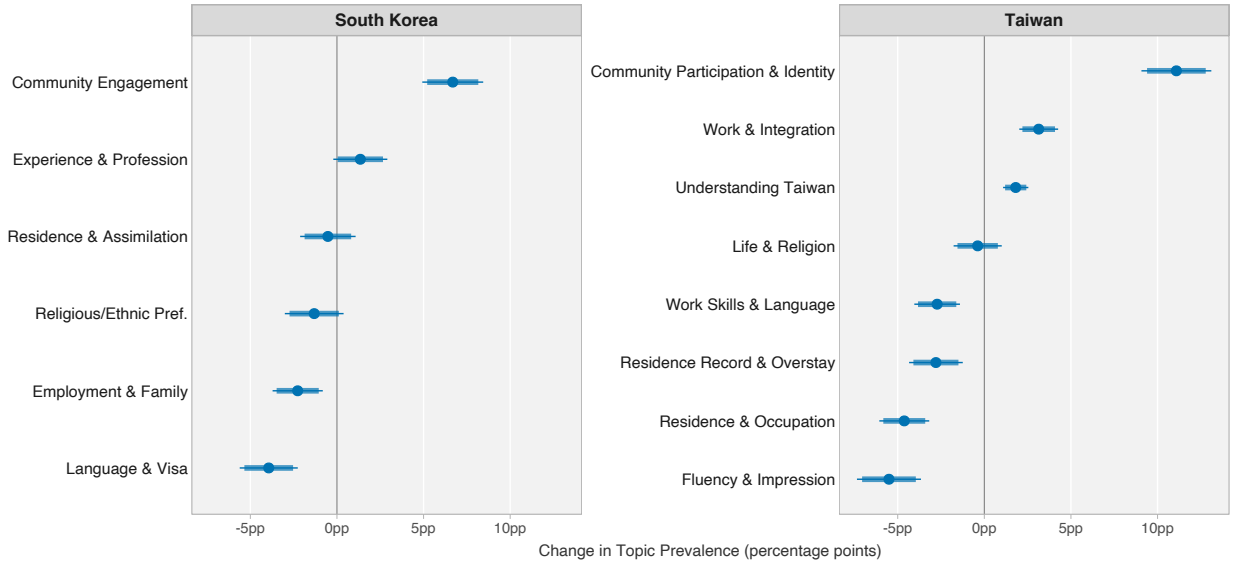

Figure 2: Effect of the randomized social integration cue on STM topic prevalence, by country. Coefficient estimates from `estimateEffect()` with 90% (thick) and 95% (thin) Hessian-based confidence intervals. South Korea: $K = 6$, $N = 1{,}734$; Taiwan: $K = 8$, $N = 1{,}905$.

LLM Classification: Code Prevalence

Using majority-vote classification (4+ of 6 models agree), functional integration is the most common substantive code in both countries (∼32%), followed by identity concern (15–21%), economic focus (19–23%), and other (20–21%). Civic commitment (active behavioral engagement) accounts for 2.0% (South Korea) and 1.0% (Taiwan) when the cue is *not* shown, rising to 16.6% and 19.2% when it *is* shown.

Separating functional integration from civic commitment makes clear that practical attributes (language, residence, law-abiding behavior) dominate respondent reasoning in both countries, distinct from the active civic engagement that the cue is designed to activate.

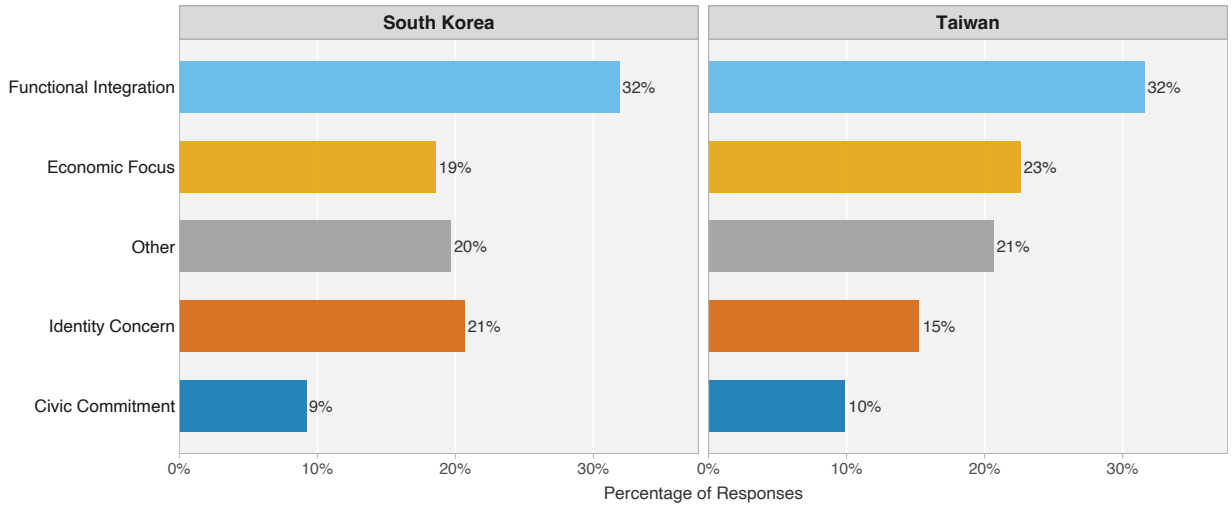

Figure 3: LLM classification: code prevalence by country. Majority-vote classification, $N = 1{,}817$ South Korea + $1{,}938$ Taiwan responses with 4-of-6 model consensus.

LLM Classification: Effect of the Social Integration Cue

In South Korea, the cue increases civic commitment by +14.7 pp (from 2.0% to 16.6%), while decreasing functional integration by -7.9 pp and economic focus by -5.6 pp; identity concern decreases modestly (-2.7 pp). The Taiwanese results are similar in direction but stronger in magnitude: civic commitment increases by +18.2 pp, economic focus decreases by -11.4 pp, functional integration by -6.8 pp; identity concern is stable. All effects are outside zero at the 95% level. Across the six individual models, civic-commitment effects range from +9.4 to +16.1 pp in South Korea and +14.4 to +18.1 pp in Taiwan, all significant. The cue effect is present across all response lengths, including responses of five characters or fewer (+7 pp; SI Appendix F). Substantive-codes-only estimates (excluding `other` from the denominator) are larger and appear in SI Table C.9.

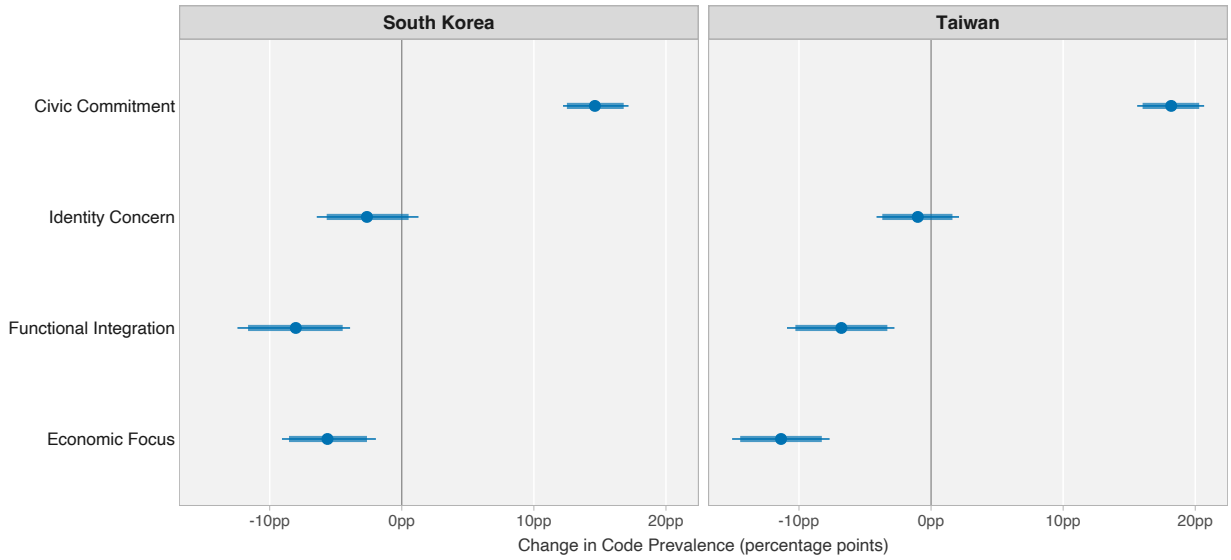

Figure 4: Effect of social integration cue on LLM-classified response themes. Majority-vote classification (4+ of 6 models). Bootstrap 90%/95% CIs (2,000 iterations).

All six LLMs produce consistent cue-effect estimates (Figure 5; per-model breakdown in SI Table C.8). Pairwise agreement ranges from 66.3% to 91.2% (Cohen's κ from 0.578 to 0.886), with Fleiss' multi-rater $\kappa = 0.745$. Agreement increases with model size. Within the Qwen 2.5 family, pairwise κ with GPT-4o-mini rises monotonically from 0.744 (3B) to 0.860 (72B), and the highest agreement overall is between Qwen 2.5 32B and 72B ($\kappa = 0.886$). Chae and Davidson (2025) report a similar pattern. Overall, 92.8% of responses receive a majority classification. The weakest performer is Llama 3.1 8B, which inflates functional integration classifications in Taiwan (43.7% vs. 30–37% for the four larger models), probably due to weaker CJK (Chinese, Japanese, Korean) language capabilities. Even Llama 8B produces civic commitment effects in the correct direction in both countries.

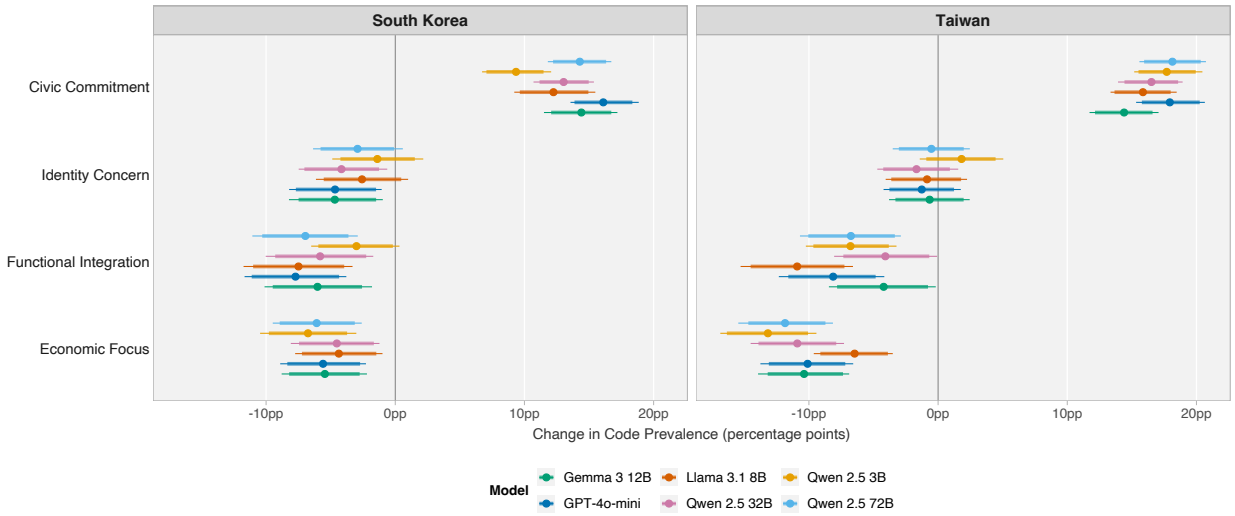

Figure 5: Cross-model robustness: cue effect estimates from six LLMs (GPT-4o-mini, Qwen 2.5 3B/32B/72B, Llama 3.1 8B, Gemma 3 12B), full corpus $N = 4{,}049$. All models produce consistent treatment effect estimates for civic commitment.

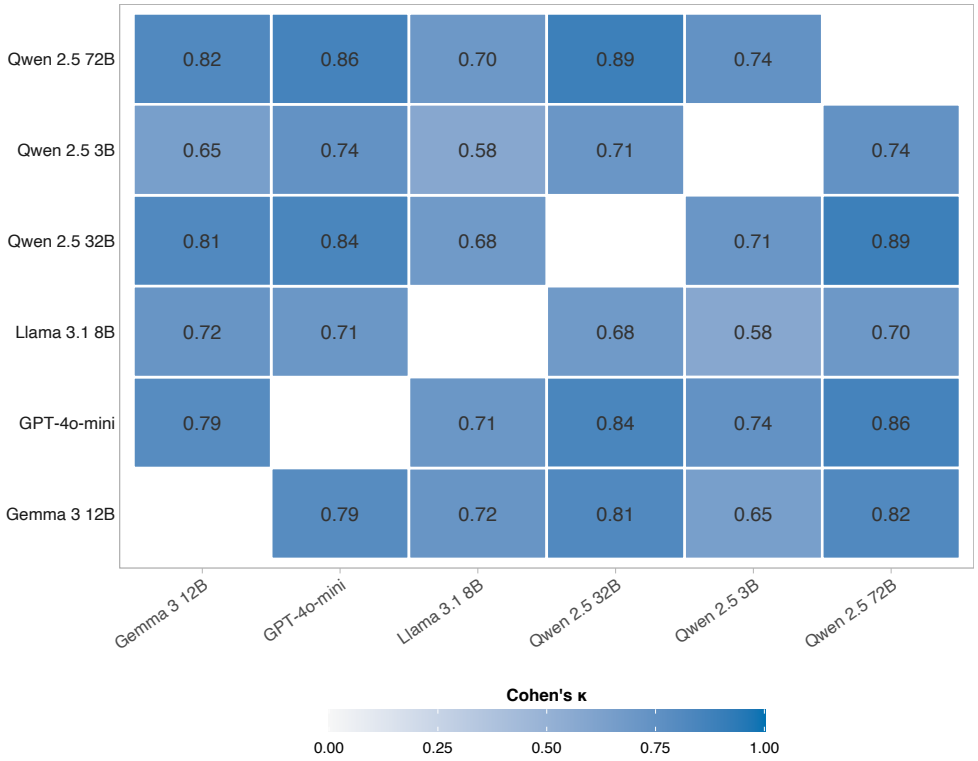

Figure 6: Cross-model agreement on majority-vote primary code: pairwise Cohen's κ for six LLMs (GPT-4o-mini, Qwen 2.5 3B/32B/72B, Llama 3.1 8B, Gemma 3 12B), $N = 4{,}049$. Fleiss' multi-rater $\kappa = 0.745$.

Stimulus Correspondence: Attribute Uptake Conditional on the Displayed Profiles

This subsection adds a complementary classification, developed after the theory-code analysis above, that conditions the model on the conjoint profiles the respondent actually saw. The new task asks which displayed attribute the response invokes and how closely the response language matches a specific level. The category structure comes from the displayed profiles rather than from a theory codebook, so the framework also applies to conjoints without a theory codebook. Two models classify all 4,049 responses against the displayed selected and unselected profiles: GPT-4o-mini and Qwen 2.5 32B. Cohen's κ between the two on the primary-attribute label is 0.848 (raw agreement 86.3%), inside the range of the strongest pairs in the six-model panel. SI Appendix D documents the schema, the convergence with theory codes, and the post-revision development of this analysis.

When the social integration cue is shown, the share of responses whose primary referent is the displayed social-integration level rises from 1.2% to 13.0% in South Korea (+11.8 pp [9.9, 13.7]) and from 1.1% to 19.9% in Taiwan (+18.8 pp [16.5, 20.9]). Qwen 2.5 32B produces nearly identical estimates (+11.9 pp in South Korea, +20.6 pp in Taiwan). Among responses that reference any displayed attribute, 73–85% reference the selected profile, indicating that respondents typically justify their choice by features of the profile they picked rather than features of the rejected one. Figure 7 summarizes the cue effect.

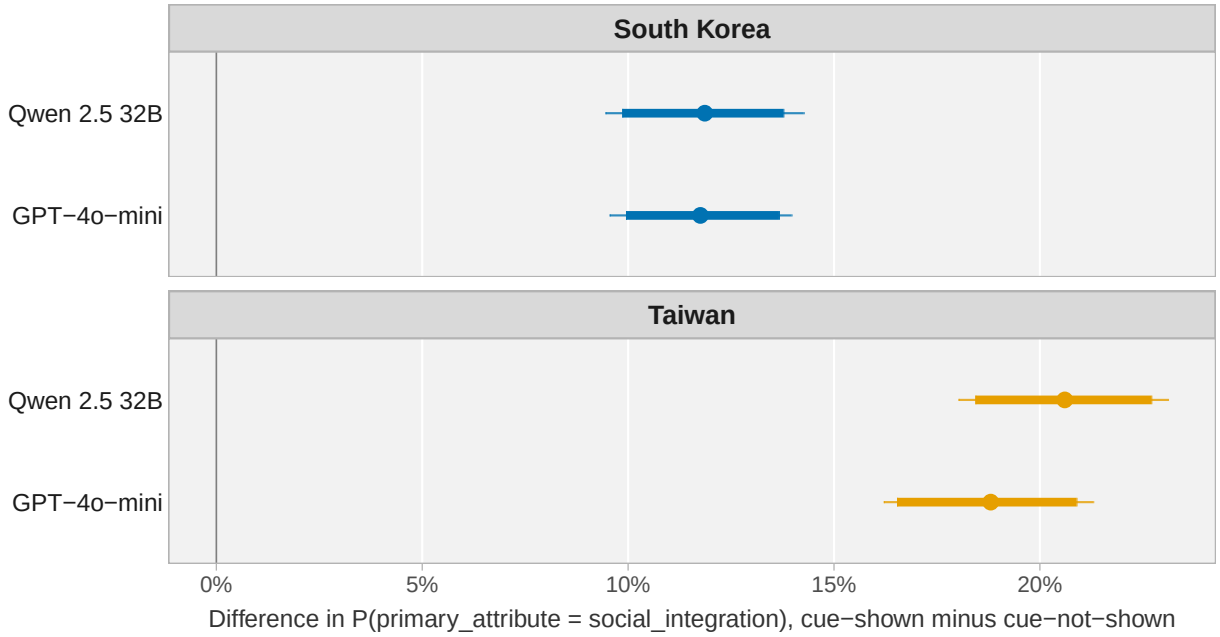

Figure 7: Stimulus correspondence: cue-shown vs. cue-not-shown difference in $P(\texttt{primary_attribute} = \texttt{social_integration})$, by country and model (GPT-4o-mini and Qwen 2.5 32B), $N = 4{,}049$. Thick bars: 90% bootstrap CI; thin bars: 95% (2,000 iterations).

The two analyses converge on the central mappings (SI Appendix D): each theory code maps predominantly onto its expected displayed attribute or attributes, with 57–66% of cases per theory category falling on the diagonal. The stimulus-grounded coding also adds resolution: "functional integration" as a theory category collapses two distinct attribute uptakes (language and residence length) that the displayed-attribute coding distinguishes. The substantive conclusion holds under either framing.

Triangulation

The cleanest comparison between methods is for civic engagement, where a single STM topic maps directly to the LLM `civic_commitment` code in each country. In South Korea, the STM "Community Engagement" topic increases by 6.7 pp while the LLM civic code increases by 14.7 pp. In Taiwan, the STM "Community Participation & Identity" topic increases by 11.4 pp while the LLM civic code increases by 18.2 pp. All effects are significant. Both methods agree on the direction, significance, and cross-country pattern: the cue activates civic reasoning, and the effect is larger in Taiwan.

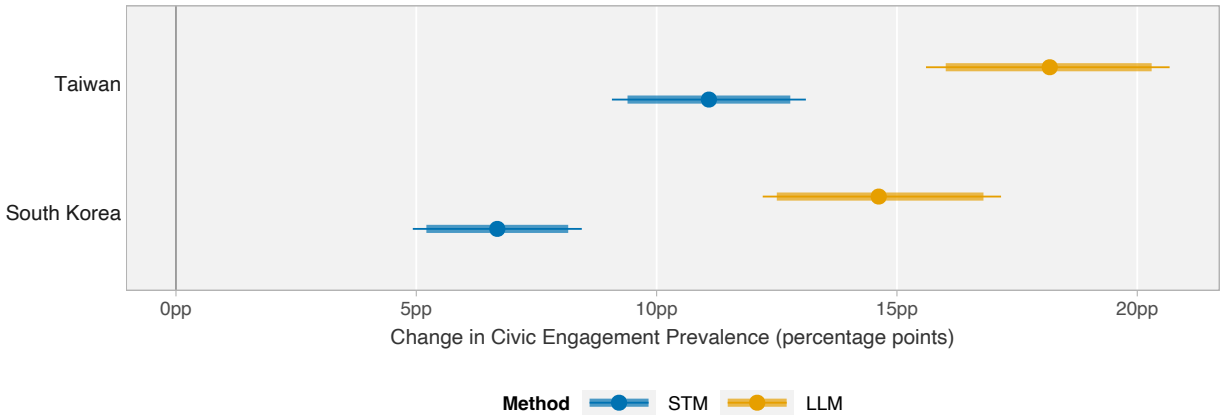

Figure 8: Triangulation: STM civic topic and LLM civic commitment treatment effects. The comparison where the topic-to-code mapping is unambiguous. Thick bars: 90% CIs; thin bars: 95% CIs.

Two factors explain why LLM estimates are larger than STM estimates. LLM codes are broader than individual STM topics, and LLM classification routes uninformative responses to `other`, producing a cleaner denominator. As diffusely assigned STM documents are excluded, the STM civic effect rises monotonically toward the LLM estimate at $\theta_{\max} \approx 0.35$–$0.40$ (SI Appendix B). For the remaining categories, the mapping between STM topics and LLM codes is not one-to-one, but the directional agreement is clear: practical and economic STM topics decline alongside the LLM functional-integration and economic-focus codes, and identity concern is stable in both methods.

Portability: A Standard Conjoint without Randomized Attributes

The primary analysis exploits within-attribute treatment randomization, a feature that most published conjoint experiments do not share. A validation framework that required such randomization would therefore apply only to a narrow subset of existing designs, and the methodological contribution would shrink accordingly. To test whether the approach transfers to the more common setup, I apply it to an earlier conjoint on immigrant *admission* in South Korea (Denney and Green, 2021). Respondents evaluated paired profiles on seven attributes (reason for application, country of origin, language skills, profession, employment plans, gender, and ethnicity) and explained their choices in an open-text response. All attributes are always shown, so there is no within-attribute cue to exploit. The question becomes whether

the two-stage workflow can recover the reasoning structure of a standard conjoint and whether it can refine the categories an earlier analysis used to describe that reasoning.

I classify the open-text responses using the same six LLM classifiers with a five-code codebook adapted to the admission context: sociotropic (social harmony, community benefit), economic (employment, fiscal concerns), integration (language, cultural adaptation), identity (ethnicity, national origin, co-ethnic preference), and other. Cross-model agreement is high ($\kappa = 0.737$ for GPT-4o-mini vs. Qwen 2.5 3B). LDA topic modeling ($K = 6$) on the Korean text produces topics that converge with the LLM codes: two topics map to functional integration (36% of documents), one to identity (17%), one to sociotropic reasoning (16%), one to economic concerns (13%), and one is mixed.

Table 4 shows the code distributions from five classifiers. Integration (18–27%), identity (20–22%), and economic reasoning (13–25%) each account for substantial shares. The "other" category captures vague or non-substantive responses (17–27%).

Code	**GPT-4o-mini**	**Qwen 3B**	**Gemma 12B**	**Qwen 32B**	**Qwen 72B**
Sociotropic	11.0	14.8	20.4	14.9	12.9
Economic	20.1	12.5	22.1	25.1	19.3
Integration	19.5	27.3	18.7	18.4	20.7
Identity	22.3	21.6	21.8	21.9	19.7
Other	27.0	23.8	17.0	18.8	27.3

Table 4: Code prevalence (%) for the immigrant admission conjoint ($N = 1{,}008$). What Denney & Green (2021) grouped as "sociotropic" reasoning here separates into sociotropic, economic, and integration codes.

The result sharpens the original study's findings. Denney and Green (2021) described a broad category of "sociotropic" reasoning without distinguishing between social-harmony arguments, economic arguments, and integration-effort arguments. Applying the five-code framework retrospectively decomposes this category into three distinct constructs. This is construct validation in a second sense. The first sense tests whether an experimental cue shifts reasoning as theorized; the second asks whether the measurement categories used in a completed study capture the reasoning the data actually contain. The

framework is therefore not limited to designs with treatment randomization. It can also be applied to existing conjoint data to refine constructs that were too coarse in the original analysis, which extends its methodological reach well beyond the subset of designs with within-attribute randomization. Full results are in Supplementary Information, Appendix E.

Calibration: LLM Classifications against Expert Human Coding

Cross-model agreement is a useful substitute when expert human coding is unavailable, but it is not a direct test of accuracy. Six models may agree because they have learned the same patterns from overlapping pretraining corpora rather than because their classifications match what a careful human expert would produce. To test how LLM classifications perform against an independent human benchmark, and to check whether the iterative codebook workflow developed in the main analysis generalizes to a different dataset, I apply the framework to a conjoint experiment on South Korean attitudes toward North Korean migrant entrepreneurship policy (Denney et al., 2024). After the conjoint task, respondents answered an open-text question explaining their policy choice. Two human coders independently classified all responses into four categories: economic rationale, normative rationale, other rationale, and uninformative. Their inter-coder agreement was high (Cohen's $\kappa = 0.881$, 92.3% raw agreement), which provides a reliable benchmark.

I classified the same responses using GPT-4o-mini and Llama 3.1 8B with a four-code codebook matching the human coding scheme. The LLMs classified English translations of the responses, matching the input the human coders used. I then compared LLM classifications to the human consensus. Because this validation uses English text, it confirms that the codebook and classification logic are well-calibrated but does not directly validate the multilingual classification pipeline that produces the main results.

The codebook required iteration. The initial version (v1) produced only fair agreement with the human coders (GPT-4o-mini $\kappa = 0.40$; Llama 3.1 8B $\kappa = 0.52$). Examining disagreements showed that both LLMs interpreted "economic" too narrowly and "uninformative" too broadly relative to the hu-

man coding. Because the conjoint is entirely about economic policy, the human coders classified policy-effectiveness language (e.g., "this policy would help them succeed") as economic, while the LLMs treated it as normative or uninformative. Broadening the economic category to include policy-effectiveness reasoning and tightening the uninformative code to cover only genuinely empty responses closed the gap across two rounds of revision.

Comparison	**Cohen's κ**	**Raw agreement**	**Landis & Koch**
Human–Human	0.881	92.3%	Almost perfect
GPT-4o-mini–Human	0.673	78.8%	Substantial
Llama 3.1 8B–Human	0.611	74.5%	Substantial
GPT-4o-mini–Llama 3.1 8B	0.717	81.5%	Substantial

Table 5: Inter-rater agreement for the N.K. entrepreneurship conjoint (v3 codebook, after two rounds of codebook revision). Human–human agreement from Denney et al. (2024). Note: N.K. = North Korea.

After calibration, both LLMs fall in the "substantial" agreement range ($\kappa > 0.6$), and the two LLMs agree with each other at $\kappa = 0.717$. A gap remains between LLM-human and human-human agreement, but the trajectory across codebook versions is the more important finding: two rounds of refinement moved GPT-4o-mini from $\kappa = 0.40$ (fair) to $\kappa = 0.67$ (substantial), a pattern that parallels the v1-to-v2 improvement in the main analysis. Classification quality is governed primarily by the codebook itself rather than by the choice of model. Table 6 shows the code distributions from four classifiers. Economic rationale dominates (50–60%), consistent with the conjoint being entirely about economic policy. Normative rationale accounts for 16–22%, and the uninformative category is small (2–7%), confirming that the codebook revision successfully tightened this residual category.

Code	Llama 8B	Gemma 12B	Qwen 32B	Qwen 72B
Economic rationale	49.8	60.0	55.4	52.3
Normative rationale	22.3	21.6	18.5	16.0
Other rationale	22.5	16.4	19.3	26.7
Uninformative	5.3	1.9	6.8	5.0

Table 6: Code prevalence (%) for the N.K. entrepreneurship conjoint ($N = 2{,}009$). Economic rationale dominates, consistent with the policy domain. Note: N.K. = North Korea.

This result has two implications for the main analysis. First, it provides external evidence that the iterative codebook workflow advocated in this paper produces meaningful gains in classification accuracy. The $0.40 \rightarrow 0.67$ trajectory observed here, moving from fair to substantial agreement, parallels the v1-to-v2 refinement in the naturalization analysis. In both cases the decisive improvement came from rewriting the codebook rather than from switching to a larger or more capable model. Codebook design is therefore the primary lever for improving classification quality, which is the load-bearing methodological claim of the paper. Second, it calibrates expectations about absolute performance. Even after careful iteration, LLM-human agreement ($\kappa \approx 0.6$–0.7) remains below expert human-human agreement ($\kappa \approx 0.9$). The six-model cross-validation in the main analysis, which achieves Fleiss' $\kappa = 0.745$ across models of very different size and architecture, is consistent with this range and suggests that multi-model consensus compensates for the gap between any single LLM and a human expert.

Interpreting LLM Confidence

The N.K. dataset, with its expert human-coded ground truth, also supplies the strongest test of the paper's third contribution: whether the token-level log-probability that a model assigns to its classification is a usable measure of classification confidence. The answer has three parts, each actionable for researchers adopting the workflow.

First, logprobs track *relative* classification difficulty. Responses where a model assigns high probability to its chosen code are also the responses where more of the six models agree ($r_s = 0.46$; Supplementary

Information, Appendix C). A low predicted probability is a useful flag that a case is ambiguous and may warrant human review.

Second, logprobs do *not* track absolute correctness. Against the human consensus on the N.K. dataset, all six models are overconfident, assigning high probabilities to classifications that disagree with human coders at substantial rates (Expected Calibration Error 0.14–0.26). Larger models are better calibrated (Qwen 2.5 72B ECE $= 0.145$ vs. Qwen 2.5 3B ECE $= 0.260$), but none are well-calibrated in absolute terms. The majority-vote benchmark on the SK/TW corpus produces much lower ECE (0.01–0.10), reflecting shared uncertainty patterns across models with overlapping pretraining data. The gap between the two benchmarks shows that inter-model agreement overstates classification reliability. Predicted probabilities indicate relative difficulty across responses; they should not be treated as probabilities of correctness.

Third, self-reported confidence labels are less informative than logprobs. When the same prompt asks the model to output a HIGH, MEDIUM, or LOW confidence tag alongside its classification, the tag is a generated token with no reliable relationship to the model's predictive distribution (Supplementary Information, Appendix C). The implication for practice is direct: the confidence label that appears in the model's text should not be used to gate review decisions; the extracted token-level logprob should.

Discussion and Conclusion

Open-weight models produce results comparable to GPT-4o-mini: all six agree on the direction and significance of treatment effects, and pairwise κ with GPT-4o-mini rises monotonically across the Qwen 2.5 family from 0.744 (3B) to 0.860 (72B), consistent with Chae and Davidson (2025). Researchers need not depend on proprietary APIs, whose outputs may shift between model versions (Barrie et al., 2025), to conduct rigorous text classification. Even the 3B model runnable on a consumer GPU produces civic commitment effects in the correct direction for every code in every country; mid-range models (12B–32B) offer a reasonable tradeoff for more fine-grained applications. Multi-model majority voting also offers a practical alternative to human-coded ground truth: when six diverse models agree on a classification, as

they do for 93% of responses here, that consensus provides usable measurement without expert coders, with a modest residual gap to human coding ($\kappa \approx 0.6$–0.7) that codebook refinement closes much of.

This approach complements existing tools for assessing respondent engagement. Prior work validates conjoint experiments against real-world behavior (Hainmueller et al., 2015) and examines visual attention using eye-tracking (Jenke et al., 2021). Open-text responses provide a different window. They reveal how respondents *reason* about profile attributes, going beyond the question of whether they attended to them. Unlike manipulation checks that condition on post-treatment responses and risk selection bias (Aronow et al., 2019), open-text validation examines the full sample. Other work scales open-ended responses on a continuous dimension (DiGiuseppe and Flynn, 2026); the approach here is categorical, aimed at what kind of reasoning respondents use and whether the treatment shifts it.

The stimulus-correspondence extension reported above addresses a separate measurement gap. Current LLM classification of open-text survey responses produces $P(\text{category} \mid \text{response})$, the probability that an answer falls into a researcher-defined code. That measure does not say whether the response refers to a stimulus the respondent was actually shown. Conditioning the model on the selected and unselected profile produces a different quantity: the probability that the response invokes a displayed attribute and matches a specific level. The framing applies to designs without within-attribute treatment randomization, since the relevant comparison is between the selected and unselected profile rather than between treatment arms, and researchers can adopt it without committing in advance to a theory-specific codebook.

The iterative codebook design process makes a broader point. Running an unsupervised model first can catch coding mistakes that would otherwise go unnoticed. The v1 codebook grouped civic engagement with language and residence under a single code; the STM showed that these move in opposite directions under the treatment, so the v2 codebook separated them. That single revision changed more classification outcomes than any other design choice in the analysis.

The classification-confidence analysis yields a practical guideline. Token-level log-probabilities are useful for flagging uncertain cases for human review, because they track relative classification difficulty and correlate with cross-model agreement ($r_s = 0.46$). They are not useful as probabilities of correctness,

because all six models are overconfident against human-coded ground truth (ECE 0.14–0.26). The self-reported confidence labels that LLMs emit as text are less informative still. Researchers embedding LLM classification in their workflow should extract logprobs, use them to triage classifications for review, and not treat them as calibrated probabilities.

Several limitations bear noting. Post-choice open-text elicitation invites post-hoc justification rather than real-time introspection; the framework establishes that treatment shifts what respondents *write*, which is necessary but not sufficient evidence that it shifts what they *think*. The substitution pattern, where civic cues displace language, residence, and economic reasoning rather than merely adding civic language, is harder to explain as mere recall. Responses are short (median 6–10 characters) and self-generated, so STM assignments are often diffuse and some considered attributes may go unwritten; the $\theta_{\max}$ sensitivity analysis in SI Appendix B quantifies the effect on STM estimates. Individual model performance on CJK text varies, and majority-vote aggregation mitigates but does not eliminate model-specific biases. Scope is also limited: the framework has been tested on immigration conjoints in two East Asian democracies with short, concrete responses; transferability to more abstract constructs, discursive responses, or lower-resource languages is open.

A final concern is response authenticity in the agentic AI era. The surveys analyzed here pre-date widespread access to agentic tools, so AI-generated contamination is not a threat to the present findings, but Westwood (2025) show that agentic systems now complete surveys while passing 99.8% of standard attention checks. A related concern is delegation: respondents who outsource open-text answers to a language model rather than writing their own. If respondents delegate their reasoning to an LLM, the analyst ends up using LLMs to classify LLM-generated text. Researchers adopting this framework should treat authenticity as an assumption to be actively verified, paired ideally with behavioral signals or design choices that make genuine participation less effortful than delegation.

Combining structural topic modeling with LLM classification, and pairing the theory-coded classification with a stimulus-grounded one, lets researchers test whether the construct an experiment is designed to measure is the construct respondents reason about, and whether the design activates that reasoning rather than something adjacent. Both methods converge in the primary application, and the

ground-truth extension confirms that codebook refinement is the principal lever for improving classification quality. Token-level log-probabilities reveal which classifications are uncertain, information that self-reported confidence labels do not reliably convey. Researchers should consider embedding open-text questions in their survey experiments; the smallest open-weight model tested here runs on a consumer GPU and produces directionally consistent results, and the validity evidence is worth the modest additional burden.

Data Availability

Replication data, code, codebooks, and all analytical outputs are available in the replication archive at [URL/DOI to be added upon acceptance]. The archive includes the analysis-ready corpus, all LLM classification outputs, STM intermediate files, and publication figures.

Pre-Registration

No analyses in this paper were preregistered. The paper develops a methodological framework, and the analytical decisions it documents (codebook iteration, topic-count selection, majority-vote threshold, the stimulus-correspondence extension reported above) are explained in Section 4 and audited via the threshold-sensitivity, $\theta_{\max}$, and response-length analyses in SI Appendix F. The N.K. application benchmarks the framework against expert human-coded classifications, providing an external check beyond cross-model agreement.

Ethics Statement

The naturalization conjoint data are original to this paper; the admission and N.K. entrepreneurship data are reanalyses of Denney and Green (2021) and Denney et al. (2024). The naturalization survey was conducted in accordance with applicable ethical standards and received institutional approvals; protocol details for the secondary datasets are reported in the original publications.

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Competing Interests

The author declares none.

Use of AI-Assisted Tools

Claude Code (Anthropic; Opus 4.6 and 4.7) was used during the preparation of this manuscript in two capacities: to assist with code cleaning and formatting for the replication archive, and for analysis confirmation and checking and for technical and substantive edits to improve the precision of the manuscript's language. All substantive ideas, analytical decisions, research design, and core writing are the author's own. The author reviewed and revised all AI-assisted output and takes full responsibility for the content of this publication.

Appendix A: Disclosure Elements

This appendix consolidates the information required by *Public Opinion Quarterly*'s Disclosure Elements policy, consistent with the American Association for Public Opinion Research (AAPOR) Transparency Initiative. Each of the three conjoint datasets analyzed in the paper receives its own disclosure table (Tables 7–9). The primary naturalization data were collected for this study; the two secondary datasets are reanalyses of previously published survey data, and full AAPOR disclosure for those surveys appears in the original publications cited below.

A.1 Naturalization Conjoint (South Korea and Taiwan, 2024)

Element	Description
Funding	Academy of Korean Studies (AKS-2026-R-094)
Population	Adults residing in South Korea and Taiwan
Sampling frame	Qualtrics' pre-existing online research panel (opt-in, non-probability)
Sample design	Stratified quota sampling on sex, age band, and geographic region to approximate national census distributions
Response rate	Not applicable (non-probability quota panel; AAPOR RR1–RR6 not computable). Completion rate among quota-filling panelists was approximately 95% in both countries
Design effects	Not computed for quota panel samples
Data collection dates	15 January 2024 to 28 June 2024
Sample sizes	South Korea: $N = 1{,}999$ (51% male; mean age 46.6; range 19–84). Taiwan: $N = 2{,}050$ (53% male; mean age 41.3; range 14–88). Full characteristics in Supplementary Information, Table A.1
Conjoint choice question	"In your opinion, which of these two individuals is more deserving of citizenship in [country]?" South Korean respondents completed 10 paired-choice tasks; Taiwanese respondents completed 7. Profiles varied on 12 attributes; levels in Supplementary Information, Table A.6
Open-text probe	"Why did you choose this person as more deserving of citizenship?" Required; no minimum length imposed
Informed consent	Qualtrics' standard panel-consent mechanism before the survey began
Human subjects protection	Institutional ethics approval received prior to data collection

Table 7: AAPOR disclosure elements for the primary naturalization conjoint.

A.2 Admission Conjoint (South Korea, 2020)

Element	Description
Original publication	Denney and Green (2021)
Population	Adults residing in South Korea
Sampling frame / design	See original publication
Response rate	See original publication
Data collection dates	2020; see original publication for exact dates
Sample size	$N = 1{,}008$ (50.1% male; 76.9% with some college or more). Sample breakdown by age cohort and ideology in Supplementary Information, Table A.2
Conjoint choice question	Paired-profile immigrant admission task; seven attributes (reason for application, country of origin, language skills, profession, employment plans, gender, ethnicity)
Open-text probe	Post-choice: respondents explained their admission choice
Informed consent and ethics	As reported in original publication

Table 8: AAPOR disclosure elements for the admission conjoint (secondary dataset).

A.3 North Korean Migrant Entrepreneurship Conjoint (South Korea, 2020)

Element	Description
Original publication	Denney et al. (2024)
Population	Adults residing in South Korea
Sampling frame / design	See original publication
Response rate	See original publication
Data collection dates	2020; see original publication for exact dates
Sample size	$N = 2{,}009$ adults in South Korea (analyzable open-text corpus from the replication data shared with this paper). Summary in Supplementary Information, Table A.3; full characteristics in original publication
Conjoint choice question	Paired-profile North Korean migrant entrepreneurship policy task
Open-text probe	Post-choice: respondents explained their policy choice
Human-coded ground truth	Two trained human coders independently classified every open-text response into four categories (economic rationale, normative rationale, other rationale, uninformative), Cohen's $\kappa = 0.881$
Informed consent and ethics	As reported in original publication

Table 9: AAPOR disclosure elements for the North Korean migrant entrepreneurship conjoint (secondary dataset).

A.4 Classification Procedure

Open-text responses were classified by six large language models: GPT-4o-mini (OpenAI API) and five open-weight models (Qwen 2.5 3B, Llama 3.1 8B, Gemma 3 12B, Qwen 2.5 32B, Qwen 2.5 72B). All models

were run with temperature $= 0$, seed $= 42$, and max_tokens $= 200$; open-weight models produce deterministic output under these parameters. GPT-4o-mini outputs are not strictly reproducible across runs due to batched inference and silent model updates. Full classification prompts, codebooks, per-model outputs, and infrastructure details appear in Supplementary Information, Appendices C and F, and in the replication archive.

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Supplementary Information

"What Were They Thinking?" Using Open-Text Responses to Validate Constructs in Survey Experiments

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A Survey Design and Sample

Respondents were recruited via Qualtrics using stratified quota sampling by sex, age, and geographic region to approximate national census distributions. Table A.1 summarizes the primary naturalization sample; Tables A.2 and A.3 provide parallel summaries for the secondary admission and N.K. entrepreneurship samples used in the paper's extensions.

	South Korea ($N = 1{,}999$)	**Taiwan** ($N = 2{,}050$)
Male	50.8%	53.4%
Mean age (years)	46.6	41.3
Age range	19–84	14–88
College or higher	80.6%	73.5%
Capital area / Northern TW	74.3%	52.8%
Cue shown	49.8%	49.1%

Table A.1: Primary naturalization sample characteristics (fielded January–June 2024). "Capital area" for South Korea includes Seoul, Gyeonggi, and Incheon; "Northern TW" includes Taipei, New Taipei, and Taoyuan.

	South Korea ($N = 1{,}008$)
Male	50.1%
Age 18–29	17.1%
Age 30–39	19.0%
Age 40–49	21.0%
Age 50–59	21.0%
Age 60+	21.8%
College or higher	76.9%

Table A.2: Secondary admission sample characteristics, derived from the replication data for Denney and Green (2021) (fielded 2020, South Korea). See the original publication for sampling procedure, ideology distribution, and additional demographics.

	South Korea ($N = 2{,}009$)
Male	50.7%
Age 20–29	15.8%
Age 30–39	15.9%
Age 40–49	19.3%
Age 50–59	20.4%
Age 60+	28.6%
College or higher	78.2%

Table A.3: Secondary N.K. migrant entrepreneurship sample characteristics, from Denney et al. (2024) (fielded August–September 2021, South Korea). Quotas were set on age, region, and sex; the sample combines a Rakuten Insights panel ($n = 1{,}666$) with a Cint panel ($n = 343$) added to address low uptake among older respondents. The replication archive shared with this paper contains only the respondent identifier and open-text responses; see the original publication for full sampling details and survey weights. Note: N.K. = North Korea.

Randomization, participant flow, and arm balance

For the primary application, the social integration attribute was randomly withheld from a respondent's full conjoint task set, creating a between-subject treatment indicator `cue_shown` $\in \{0, 1\}$. Randomization was performed by Qualtrics' embedded survey-flow randomizer at the start of each survey session, simple Bernoulli with target rate 0.5; no blocking or stratification was applied. Allocation is concealed in the sense that respondents and the analyst are unaware of arm assignment until data extraction. Online self-administered surveys cannot blind the participant; the LLM classifiers are mechanically blind to `cue_shown` because the corpus delivered to them contains only the open-text response (no profile or treatment metadata), and the STM uses `cue_shown` as a prevalence covariate so the model does not select treatment-balanced subsets.

Table A.4 reports the participant flow stratified by `cue_shown`. Recruitment, completion, and non-empty open-text rates are 100% in both arms in both countries by design (the open-text item is required and recruitment proceeded only against quota completion). Two stages remove documents from downstream analyses: STM preprocessing drops responses that produce zero features after morphological analysis and stopword removal (265 in South Korea, 145 in Taiwan), and LLM majority-vote classification excludes responses without 4-of-6 model consensus on a single code. Both exclusions are balanced across arms within each country: $\chi^2(1) = 0.56$, $p = 0.45$ for the LLM exclusion in South Korea and

$\chi^2(1) = 0.76, p = 0.38$ for Taiwan.

	South Korea		Taiwan	
Stage	**Cue 0**	**Cue 1**	**Cue 0**	**Cue 1**
Randomized	1,003	996	1,043	1,007
Completed survey	1,003	996	1,043	1,007
Non-empty open-text	1,003	996	1,043	1,007
Analyzed in STM (after preprocessing)	868	866	967	938
Analyzed in LLM majority vote (4/6)	917	900	991	947

Table A.4: Participant flow by treatment arm. The randomized counts are also the counts at every subsequent stage prior to text-analytic preprocessing. STM preprocessing drops responses with zero features after morphological analysis (kiwipiepy for Korean, quanteda for Chinese) and stopword removal. LLM majority vote excludes responses without 4-of-6 model consensus. Both exclusions are balanced across arms in each country (LLM: $\chi^2_{\text{SK}} = 0.56,\ p = 0.45$; $\chi^2_{\text{TW}} = 0.76,\ p = 0.38$). The intent-to-treat (ITT) primary analysis is run on all randomized respondents.

Demographic balance across the cue-shown arms in the South Korea and Taiwan samples is reported in Table A.5. Sex, age, education, and region distributions are within sampling tolerance of one another, consistent with the simple Bernoulli randomization.

	South Korea			Taiwan		
Covariate	**Cue 0**	**Cue 1**	**SMD**	**Cue 0**	**Cue 1**	**SMD**
N	1,003	996		1,043	1,007	
Male (%)	50.9	50.6	0.006	54.4	52.3	0.042
Mean age (years)	46.7	46.5	0.014	41.4	41.1	0.021
College or higher (%)	79.8	81.5	0.043	74.7	72.2	0.057

Table A.5: Pre-treatment covariate balance by cue-shown arm. SMD = standardized mean difference (Cohen's h for proportions, Cohen's d for continuous). All SMDs are below the conventional 0.10 imbalance threshold.

Table A.6 presents the full set of 12 attributes used in the conjoint experiment on immigrant naturalization, with all attribute levels. Profiles were shown to respondents in South Korea and Taiwan; respondents chose which immigrant they considered "more deserving of citizenship." All attributes and levels were independently randomized across profiles.

Attribute	Levels
Social integration	Only associates with fellow expatriates; Often spends time alone; Co-hosts monthly multicultural events; Volunteers weekly at a local community center
Ethnicity	Co-ethnic; Not co-ethnic
Religion	Not religious; Christian; Buddhist; Muslim
Country of origin	United States; China; Indonesia; Brazil (SK) / South Korea (TW); the Philippines
Occupation	Computer programmer; Farmer; Unemployed; Office worker
Family status	Single; Married; Married with children
Age	27; 36; 47; 58
Sex	Male; Female
Prior work experience	None; Worked in home country; Worked previously in country
Prior trips	Visited once with friends; Previously overstayed visa; Visited on short-term working visa
Years since arrival	2; 7; 12
Language ability	None; Broken; Conversational; Fluent

Table A.6: Conjoint experiment: full attribute table (12 attributes with levels). The social integration attribute was randomly withheld from some profiles, creating the cue-shown vs. cue-not-shown treatment comparison. Country of origin levels differ slightly between the South Korea and Taiwan surveys.

B Structural Topic Models

B.1 Topic labels and top terms

Tables B.1 and B.2 present the topic labels and mean prevalence for each STM model. Top terms (FREX and probability) are in Korean and Traditional Chinese, respectively, and are available in the replication code.

Topic	Label	Prevalence (%)
1	Community Engagement	19.0
2	Language & Visa	11.7
3	Religious/Ethnic Preference	23.3
4	Residence & Assimilation	21.4
5	Experience & Profession	11.9
6	Employment & Family	12.7

Table B.1: South Korea STM topics ($K = 6$). Prevalence is the mean document-topic proportion across the corpus.

Topic	Label	Prevalence (%)
1	Fluency & Impression	18.7
2	Life & Religion	7.3
3	Work & Integration	18.7
4	Residence & Occupation	11.0
5	Understanding Taiwan	11.3
6	Work Skills & Language	9.3
7	Community Participation & Identity	14.6
8	Residence Record & Overstay	9.1

Table B.2: Taiwan STM topics ($K = 8$). Prevalence is the mean document-topic proportion across the corpus.

B.2 Topic assignment clarity and threshold sensitivity

Structural topic models assign every document a probability distribution over all K topics, regardless of content quality. A substantive response that clearly discusses a single theme receives a concentrated

distribution (high θ_{max}), while an uninformative or ambiguous response receives a diffuse distribution spread across topics. This section examines the clarity of STM topic assignments and how treatment effect estimates change when diffusely assigned documents are excluded.

The open-text responses in this study are extremely short. After morphological analysis (kiwipiepy for Korean, quanteda for Chinese) and stopword removal, 41% of South Korean documents and 30% of Taiwanese documents contain a single token; the median is 2 tokens in both countries. Standard STM preprocessing drops documents that produce zero features (265 of 1,999 in South Korea, 145 of 2,050 in Taiwan), but no minimum word count threshold is applied, consistent with standard practice in the STM literature (Roberts et al., 2014). STM handles short documents through its Bayesian prior: documents with few words receive posterior topic proportions dominated by the prior rather than the data, producing appropriately diffuse assignments that express the model's uncertainty.

Figure B.1 shows the distribution of θ_{max} (the maximum topic probability for each document) in both countries. The dashed orange line marks the uniform distribution ($1/K$: 0.167 for South Korea, 0.125 for Taiwan), and the dotted blue line marks a moderate threshold of $\theta_{\text{max}} = 0.30$. In South Korea ($K = 6$), the median θ_{max} is 0.315, and only 3.2% of documents exceed 0.50. In Taiwan ($K = 8$), the median is 0.303 with 11.5% above 0.50. The diffuse assignments are a direct consequence of the short document lengths: with 1–2 tokens, the posterior cannot move far from the prior.

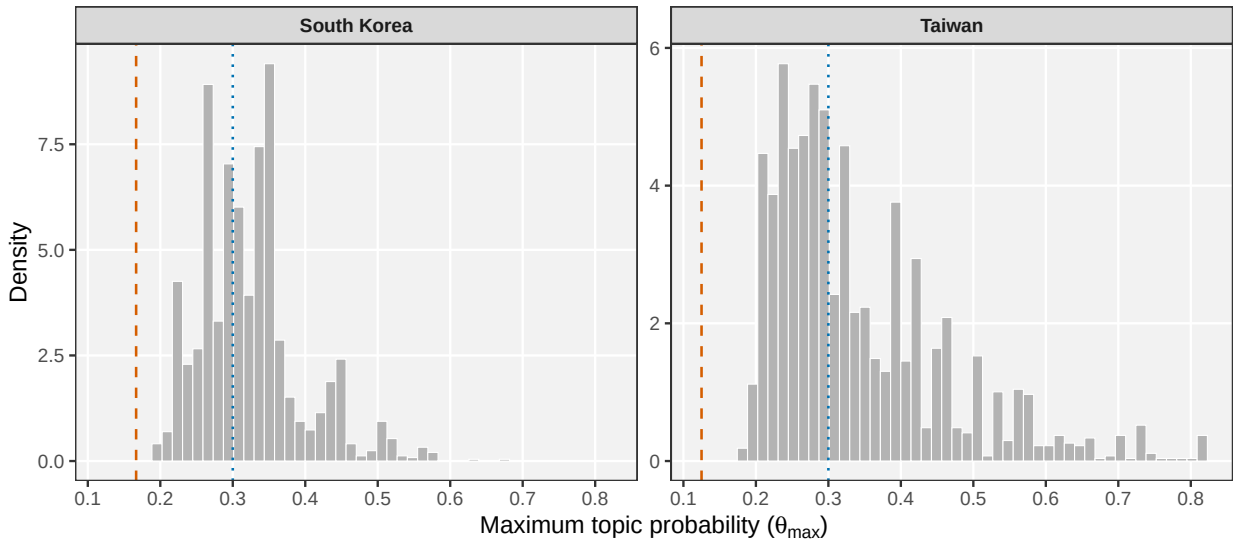

Figure B.1: Distribution of maximum topic probability (θ_{max}) for each document. Dashed orange: uniform baseline ($1/K$). Dotted blue: moderate filtering threshold ($\theta_{\text{max}} = 0.30$). Most documents are diffusely assigned across topics, especially in South Korea where $K = 6$ constrains the topic space.

Figure B.2 shows how the civic topic treatment effect changes as the minimum $\theta_{\max}$ threshold increases (i.e., as diffusely assigned documents are progressively excluded). The solid lines show STM civic topic effects at each threshold; the dashed horizontal lines show the LLM majority-vote civic commitment estimates for comparison.

As the threshold rises, the STM civic effect increases monotonically in both countries. At $\theta_{\max} \geq 0.30$ (retaining 59% of South Korean and 51% of Taiwanese documents), the effects rise to +10.5 pp and +18.2 pp, respectively. The STM estimates cross the LLM estimates around $\theta_{\max} \approx 0.35$–$0.40$, and at higher thresholds the STM effects substantially exceed the LLM estimates (reflecting the smaller and potentially unrepresentative samples that remain).

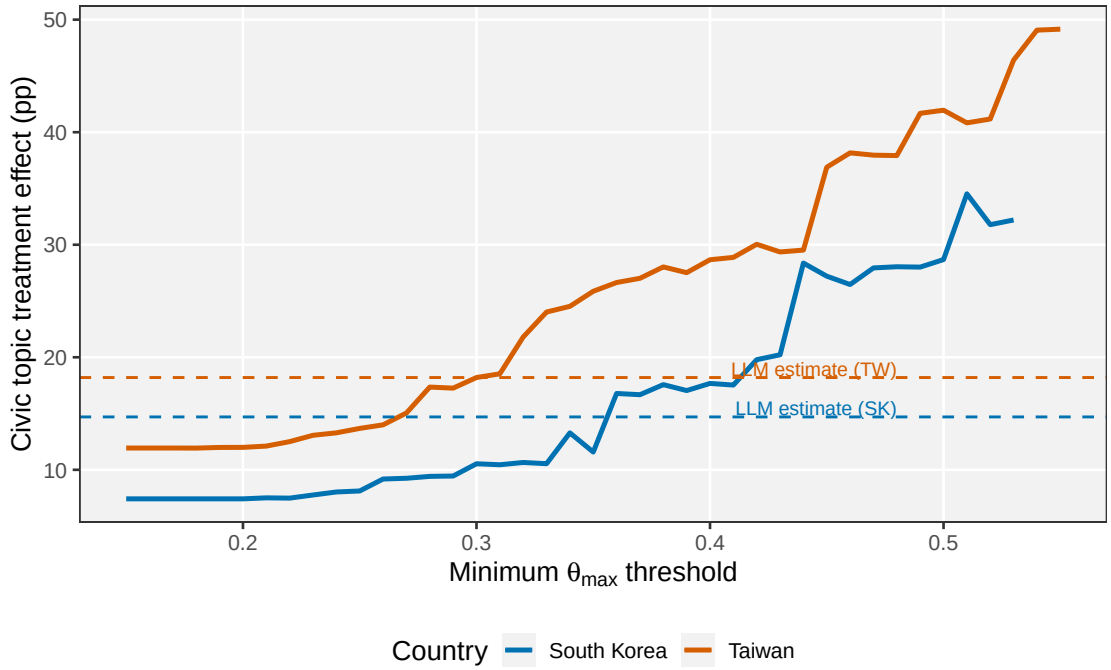

Figure B.2: Sensitivity of the civic topic treatment effect to $\theta_{\max}$ thresholds. Solid lines: STM civic topic effect (mean θ difference, cue-shown minus cue-not-shown). Dashed lines: LLM majority-vote civic commitment estimates. As diffusely assigned documents are excluded, the STM effect increases and approaches or exceeds the LLM estimate.

Table B.3 summarizes these results at selected thresholds.

Min. $\theta_{\max}$	South Korea		Taiwan	
	Docs retained	Civic effect (pp)	Docs retained	Civic effect (pp)
0 (all)	1,734 (100%)	+7.4	1,905 (100%)	+11.9
0.25	1,499 (86%)	+8.1	1,463 (77%)	+13.7
0.30	1,014 (59%)	+10.5	964 (51%)	+18.2
0.35	505 (29%)	+11.6	681 (36%)	+25.9
0.40	226 (13%)	+17.7	476 (25%)	+28.7
LLM majority-vote (for comparison)				
—	1,820 (91%)	+14.7	1,938 (94%)	+18.2

Table B.3: Civic topic treatment effect at different $\theta_{\max}$ thresholds. STM effects are raw mean θ differences (cue-shown minus cue-not-shown), which differ slightly from the `estimateEffect()` regression coefficients reported in the main text (e.g., +7.4 here vs. +6.7 in the main text for South Korea at threshold 0). The STM effect increases as diffusely assigned documents are excluded. At $\theta_{\max} \geq 0.30$, STM estimates approach the LLM majority-vote estimates. The LLM row shows the majority-vote civic commitment effect for comparison; the "docs retained" count for the LLM excludes responses without majority agreement (7.2% of the corpus).

This analysis illustrates a structural difference between the two methods. STM distributes every document, including uninformative ones, across the entire topic space. This dilutes treatment effects because noise documents receive non-trivial proportions on treatment-sensitive topics. LLM classification handles this differently: the explicit `other` category absorbs uninformative responses, effectively filtering them before treatment effects are computed on the substantive codes. The $\theta_{\max}$ threshold analysis is the STM analogue of this filtering. As the threshold increases and noisy documents are removed, the STM estimates converge toward (and eventually exceed) the LLM estimates, confirming that the difference in effect magnitudes between the two methods is driven by how each handles uninformative text rather than by substantive disagreement about the treatment effect.

C LLM Classification

C.1 Codebook

The codebook follows the structured format recommended by Halterman & Keith (2025), with each code defined by a label, definition, clarification (inclusion criteria), and negative clarification (exclusion criteria). Each code also includes few-shot examples in both Korean and Traditional Chinese.

Code	Definition and Scope
`civic_commitment`	Participation in community life: volunteering, community organizing, social participation, cultural events, helping neighbors. The respondent cites engagement directed outward toward the community.
`functional_integration`	Individual-level adaptation: language competence, residence duration, law-abiding behavior. The respondent cites practical prerequisites for functioning in the host country, rather than participation in community life.
`identity_concern`	Ethnic, cultural, or national identity concerns. Includes religion and ethnicity when used as criteria for evaluating immigrants.
`economic_focus`	Economic contributions and qualifications: jobs, taxes, career, occupation, work experience, financial self-sufficiency.
`other`	Truly uninformative responses: filler words, gibberish, meta-comments about the survey. Brevity alone is never sufficient reason for this code.

Table C.1: LLM classification codebook (v2, 5 codes). The main refinement from v1 was separating `functional_integration` from `civic_commitment` based on STM evidence that language and residence topics decrease with the civic integration cue.

C.2 Infrastructure and parse errors

Table C.2 provides technical details for each classifier. All models used temperature $= 0$, seed $= 42$, and a maximum of 200 output tokens. Open-weight models were served via Ollama.

Model	Parameters	Infrastructure	Parse Errors
GPT-4o-mini	—	OpenAI API	0
Qwen 2.5 3B	3B	Consumer GPU (NVIDIA RTX 3060 Ti, 8GB)	38
Llama 3.1 8B	8B	Consumer GPU (NVIDIA RTX 3060 Ti, 8GB)	0
Gemma 3 12B	12B	University HPC, NVIDIA A100	1
Qwen 2.5 32B	32B	University HPC, NVIDIA A100, 4-bit quantization	0
Qwen 2.5 72B	72B	University HPC, NVIDIA A100 80GB, 4-bit quantization	0

Table C.2: LLM infrastructure and parse error counts. Parse errors indicate responses where the model output could not be parsed into a valid JSON classification; these responses are excluded from agreement and prevalence calculations. Qwen 2.5 3B accounts for nearly all parse errors (38 of 39 total across all models), consistent with smaller models producing less reliable structured output.

C.3 Per-model code distributions

Table C.3 presents the code distribution for each of the six LLM classifiers, by country.

Model	Country	Civic	Functional	Identity	Economic	Other
GPT-4o-mini	South Korea	11.7	28.5	21.2	17.5	21.0
GPT-4o-mini	Taiwan	10.8	31.1	14.6	21.1	22.3
Qwen 2.5 3B	South Korea	10.7	19.5	20.4	21.4	28.1
Qwen 2.5 3B	Taiwan	11.3	21.2	16.8	25.2	25.5
Llama 3.1 8B	South Korea	14.7	36.4	21.1	18.5	9.4
Llama 3.1 8B	Taiwan	10.7	43.7	16.2	14.8	14.6
Gemma 3 12B	South Korea	12.5	35.5	22.3	16.9	12.7
Gemma 3 12B	Taiwan	10.9	36.7	15.0	22.0	15.4
Qwen 2.5 32B	South Korea	7.5	33.7	20.0	18.7	20.1
Qwen 2.5 32B	Taiwan	9.0	32.1	15.6	22.8	20.5
Qwen 2.5 72B	South Korea	9.4	30.7	18.9	19.4	21.6
Qwen 2.5 72B	Taiwan	10.7	30.0	14.7	23.4	21.2

Table C.3: Code distribution by model and country (% of classified responses). Llama 3.1 8B shows elevated functional integration in Taiwan (43.7%) relative to the four larger models (30.0–36.7%), likely reflecting weaker CJK language performance. Qwen 2.5 3B shows elevated `other` rates (25–28%), consistent with lower classification confidence at smaller model sizes.

C.4 Cross-model agreement

Table C.4 presents pairwise raw agreement rates and Cohen's κ for all 15 model pairs.

Model 1	Model 2	Agreement (%)	Cohen's κ
GPT-4o-mini	Qwen 2.5 3B	79.7	0.744
GPT-4o-mini	Llama 3.1 8B	77.2	0.706
GPT-4o-mini	Gemma 3 12B	83.9	0.792
GPT-4o-mini	Qwen 2.5 32B	87.6	0.841
GPT-4o-mini	Qwen 2.5 72B	89.1	0.860
Qwen 2.5 3B	Llama 3.1 8B	66.3	0.578
Qwen 2.5 3B	Gemma 3 12B	71.8	0.646
Qwen 2.5 3B	Qwen 2.5 32B	77.2	0.710
Qwen 2.5 3B	Qwen 2.5 72B	79.6	0.741
Llama 3.1 8B	Gemma 3 12B	79.0	0.722
Llama 3.1 8B	Qwen 2.5 32B	75.7	0.683
Llama 3.1 8B	Qwen 2.5 72B	76.8	0.700
Gemma 3 12B	Qwen 2.5 32B	85.7	0.815
Gemma 3 12B	Qwen 2.5 72B	85.8	0.816
Qwen 2.5 32B	Qwen 2.5 72B	91.2	0.886
Fleiss' multi-rater κ			**0.745**

Table C.4: Pairwise agreement rates and Cohen's κ for all 15 model pairs ($N = 4{,}049$ responses). Agreement increases with model size: within the Qwen 2.5 family, κ with GPT-4o-mini rises from 0.744 (3B) to 0.841 (32B) to 0.860 (72B). The highest pairwise agreement is between Qwen 2.5 32B and 72B ($\kappa = 0.886$).

C.5 Model confidence: self-reported ratings

Each LLM classifier reports a self-assessed confidence level (HIGH, MEDIUM, or LOW) alongside its classification. Table C.5 summarizes the proportion of HIGH-confidence classifications by model. These labels are generated tokens whose values do not correspond to calibrated probabilities, and HIGH rates vary across models more than classification accuracy does; the token-level logprobs in the next section are the more informative confidence measure.

Model	South Korea (% HIGH)	Taiwan (% HIGH)
GPT-4o-mini	80.9	87.9
Qwen 2.5 3B	69.0	69.9
Llama 3.1 8B	49.3	60.8
Gemma 3 12B	74.9	81.6
Qwen 2.5 32B	53.3	70.0
Qwen 2.5 72B	48.3	60.0

Table C.5: Proportion of HIGH-confidence classifications by model and country. Rates vary widely across models of similar performance, suggesting that self-reported confidence captures model-specific verbosity rather than classification quality.

C.6 Model confidence: token-level probabilities and calibration

A better measure of model uncertainty comes from the token-level log-probabilities (logprobs) that language models assign during generation. When the model produces the classification label (e.g., `civic_commitment`) inside the JSON output, the log-probability of the first distinguishing token reflects the model's predictive distribution over the five candidate codes. Unlike the self-reported confidence rating, this probability is not a generated token but a readout of the model's softmax distribution at the point of classification.

For each of the six models and all three datasets, I extract the logprob of the first code token and convert it to a probability ($p = e^{\text{logprob}}$). The question is whether these probabilities are calibrated: does the predicted probability correspond to actual classification accuracy?

Calibration against inter-rater agreement (SK/TW)

For the South Korea and Taiwan corpora, where no human ground truth exists, "correct" is defined as agreeing with the majority-vote classification (4+ of 6 models). Responses where models assign higher token-level probability to the classification label are also responses where more models agree on that classification ($r_s = 0.46$, $p < 0.001$). Figure C.1 shows the relationship: mean predicted probability rises from 0.81 when only two models agree to 0.98 when all six agree.

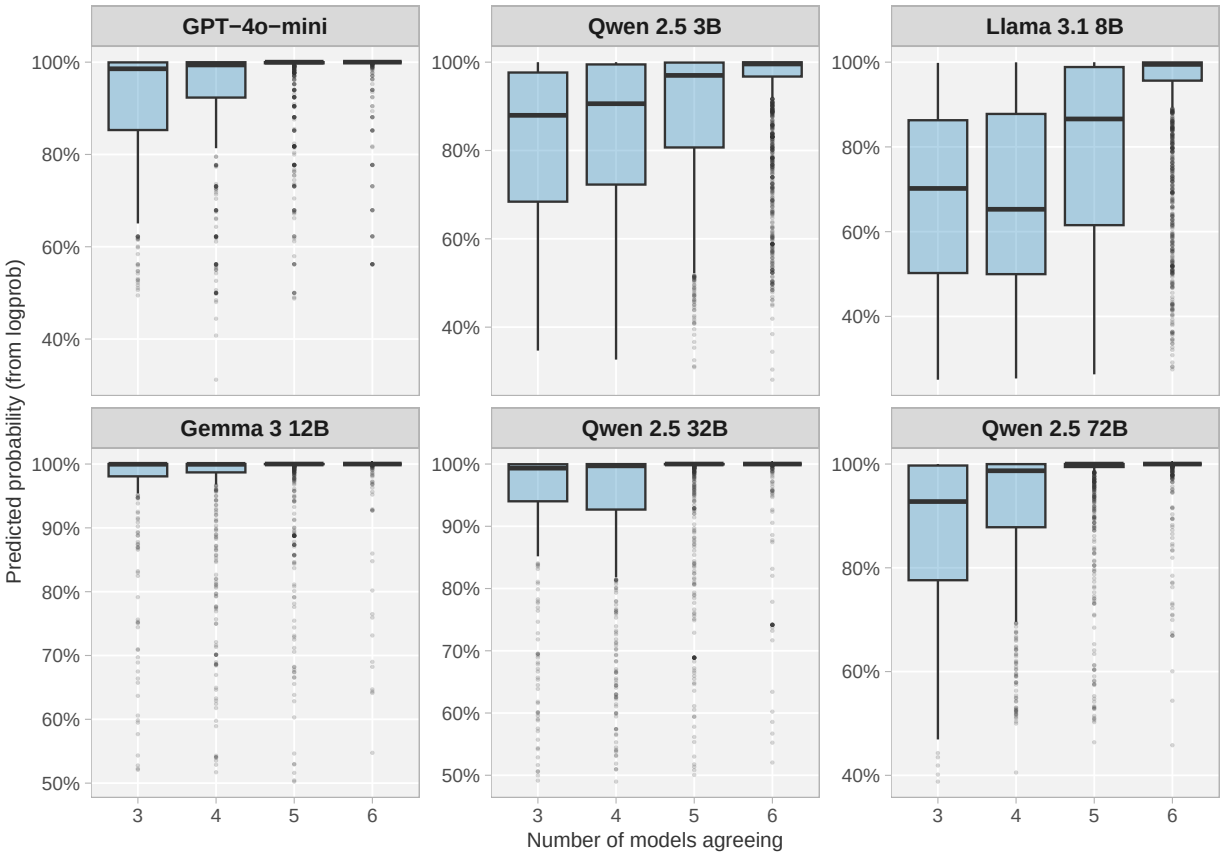

Figure C.1: Distribution of predicted probability (from token logprobs) by the number of models agreeing on the classification. Higher model certainty corresponds to broader cross-model consensus.

Calibration against human ground truth (NK entrepreneurship)

The NK entrepreneurship dataset provides the strongest calibration test because it includes adjudicated human-coded ground truth. Here, "correct" means agreement with the expert consensus code. Figure C.2 plots calibration curves for both datasets side by side: predicted probability (binned into deciles) against observed accuracy. A perfectly calibrated model falls along the diagonal. Against human ground truth (left panel), all six models sit below the diagonal: they are overconfident. Even when assigning 90%+ probability, accuracy against human codes is only 60–85%. ECE ranges from 0.145 (Qwen 2.5 72B) to 0.261 (Gemma 3 12B); larger models are better calibrated. Against the SK/TW majority vote (right panel), the same models track the diagonal much more closely (ECE 0.012–0.097). The gap illustrates that inter-model agreement inflates apparent calibration: models that share pretraining data are uncertain about the same responses, so the majority vote is a lenient benchmark. The NK ground-truth comparison is the more realistic assessment.

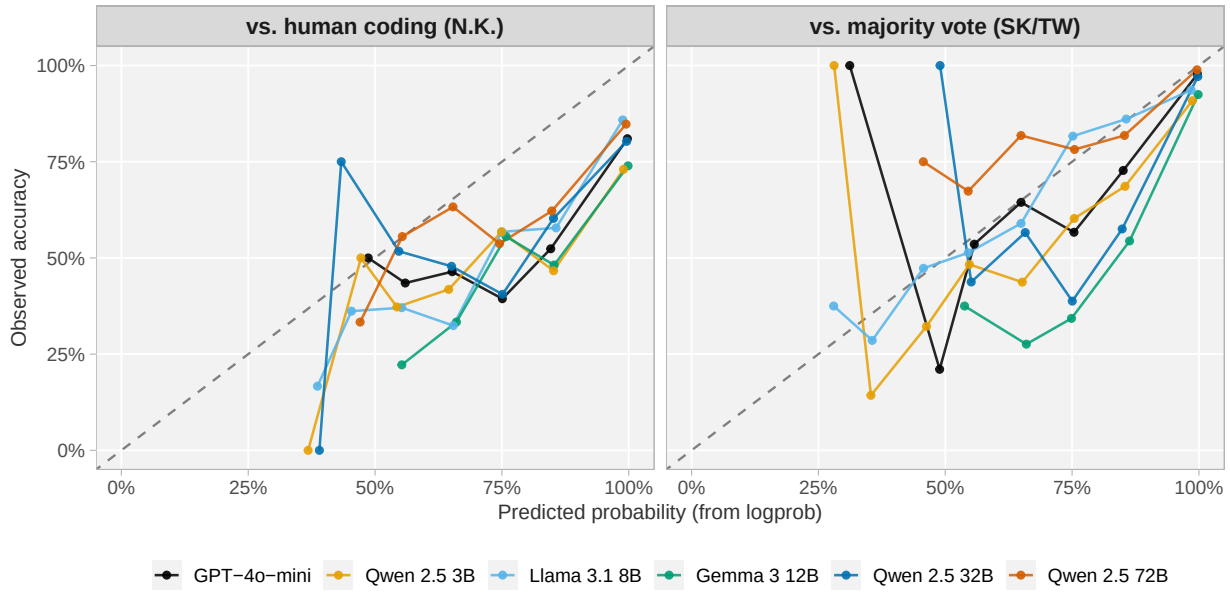

Figure C.2: Calibration curves for the six models against two ground-truth references. Left: N.K. entrepreneurship dataset (vs. human-adjudicated codes); models fall below the diagonal and are overconfident. Right: SK/TW corpus (vs. majority-vote classification); models track the diagonal more closely. The dashed line marks perfect calibration. Per-model ECE values are reported in Table C.6. Note: N.K. = North Korea.

Model	ECE (SK/TW)	ECE (N.K.)	r_s (logprob vs. n_{agree})
GPT-4o-mini	0.026	0.192	0.657
Qwen 2.5 3B	0.097	0.260	0.361
Llama 3.1 8B	0.045	0.159	0.570
Gemma 3 12B	0.084	0.261	0.640
Qwen 2.5 32B	0.038	0.196	0.621
Qwen 2.5 72B	0.012	0.145	0.637

Table C.6: Expected Calibration Error (ECE) and Spearman correlation between token-level logprobs and inter-rater agreement (n_{agree}), by model. SK/TW calibration is measured against majority vote; N.K. calibration is measured against human-adjudicated ground truth. Models appear well-calibrated against each other (low ECE for SK/TW) but overconfident relative to human coding (high ECE for N.K.). Note: N.K. = North Korea.

Self-reported confidence vs. token probability

The correlation between self-reported confidence (coded as LOW = 1, MEDIUM = 2, HIGH = 3) and the token-level probability is weak to moderate, ranging from $r_s = 0.19$ (GPT-4o-mini) to $r_s = 0.57$

(Llama 3.1 8B). This confirms that self-reported confidence ratings carry some information about actual model certainty but are not a reliable substitute for probability-based uncertainty measures. LLMs are generally not calibrated classifiers in the way that, for example, logistic regression models are calibrated by construction. The token probabilities are informative about relative confidence but should not be interpreted as true probabilities of correctness.

In practice, token-level logprobs, when available, provide a more informative uncertainty signal than self-reported confidence ratings. Responses where the model assigns low probability to its chosen code are candidates for manual review or exclusion. In a multi-model framework, logprobs and inter-rater agreement provide complementary uncertainty estimates: logprobs measure within-model uncertainty, while agreement measures between-model uncertainty.

Validity of the logprob measure

The log-probability is computed over the model's entire vocabulary (over 100,000 tokens) rather than over the five valid classification codes alone. A natural concern is whether the logprob reflects classification confidence or merely token-level noise (e.g., competition between spelling variants like `none` and `NONE` rather than between substantive codes). Table C.7 addresses this directly. For GPT-4o-mini, the five valid code prefixes capture over 99% of the probability mass for every response. The mean probability distribution, conditional on the chosen code, shows strong diagonal dominance (96–98% on the chosen code) with the remaining mass distributed among the four competing codes. For the 9% of responses where the model assigns less than 90% probability to the chosen code, the top alternatives are competing substantive codes rather than spelling variants. This confirms that the classification prompt effectively constrains the model's predictive distribution to the codebook categories, making the logprob a valid proxy for classification confidence.

Chosen code	P(civic)	P(funct.)	P(econ.)	P(ident.)	P(none)
Civic commitment	**.963**	.018	.007	.007	.006
Functional integration	.006	**.983**	.005	.002	.003
Economic focus	.005	.009	**.980**	.002	.004
Identity concern	.007	.005	.002	**.962**	.024
None of above	.001	.009	.003	.016	**.970**

Table C.7: Mean predicted probability distribution over the five classification codes, conditional on the chosen code (GPT-4o-mini, SK/TW corpus). Rows sum to ≈1.0; residual mass on non-code tokens is <0.001 in all cases. The diagonal dominance confirms that the classification prompt concentrates the model's predictive distribution onto the valid codes, making the logprob a valid measure of classification confidence.

C.7 Per-model cue effects

Table C.8 presents the treatment effect of the social integration cue on each classification code for every model individually, without majority-vote aggregation. Each row shows the change in code prevalence (in percentage points) when the cue is shown versus not shown, computed from that model's full set of classifications.

All six models, from the smallest (Qwen 2.5 3B, runnable on a consumer GPU) to the largest (Qwen 2.5 72B, requiring a university HPC node), agree on the direction of every substantive effect. Civic commitment increases in both countries across all models; functional integration and economic focus decrease; identity concern is stable.

Model	Country	Civic Commitment	Functional Integration	Economic Focus	Identity Concern
Proprietary					
GPT-4o-mini	South Korea	+16.1	−7.8	−5.7	−4.6
GPT-4o-mini	Taiwan	+18.0	−8.0	−10.2	−1.2
Open-weight (Qwen 2.5 family, size scaling)					
Qwen 2.5 3B	South Korea	+9.4	−2.9	−6.8	−1.3
Qwen 2.5 3B	Taiwan	+17.7	−6.8	−13.2	+1.8
Qwen 2.5 32B	South Korea	+13.2	−5.8	−4.6	−4.3
Qwen 2.5 32B	Taiwan	+16.6	−4.0	−10.9	−1.7
Qwen 2.5 72B	South Korea	+14.4	−7.0	−6.1	−3.0
Qwen 2.5 72B	Taiwan	+18.1	−6.7	−11.9	−0.6
Open-weight (other model families)					
Llama 3.1 8B	South Korea	+12.2	−7.6	−4.4	−2.5
Llama 3.1 8B	Taiwan	+15.9	−10.9	−6.5	−0.8
Gemma 3 12B	South Korea	+14.4	−6.1	−5.5	−4.6
Gemma 3 12B	Taiwan	+14.4	−4.2	−10.4	−0.7

Table C.8: Change in code prevalence (percentage points) when the social integration cue is shown, by model and country. Each model's classifications are used independently; no majority-vote aggregation is applied. The `other` category is omitted. All models agree on the direction of all substantive effects. The Qwen 2.5 family (3B, 32B, 72B) permits direct comparison of model size effects within the same architecture.

C.8 Cue effect by code (majority vote)

Table C.9 presents the prevalence of each substantive code when the social integration cue was shown versus not shown, using majority-vote classification (4+ of 6 models agree). The `other` category is excluded.

Country	Code	No Cue (%)	Cue (%)	Diff (pp)
South Korea	Civic Commitment	2.4	20.9	+18.5
South Korea	Functional Integration	44.2	35.0	−9.2
South Korea	Identity Concern	27.1	24.3	−2.8
South Korea	Economic Focus	26.3	19.8	−6.5
Taiwan	Civic Commitment	1.3	24.4	+23.1
Taiwan	Functional Integration	43.7	35.6	−8.1
Taiwan	Identity Concern	19.7	18.7	−1.0
Taiwan	Economic Focus	35.3	21.3	−14.0

Table C.9: Prevalence of each classification code by treatment condition, using majority-vote classification (4+ of 6 models agree). Differences are in percentage points. The `other` category is excluded; percentages are computed among substantive codes only.

D Stimulus Correspondence and Attribute Uptake

D.1 What this appendix adds

The classification reported in Appendix C is stimulus-blind. Each response is assigned to a code defined by theory (`civic_commitment`, `functional_integration`, etc.) without the model seeing the conjoint profiles the respondent actually evaluated. This appendix reports a second classification that conditions the model on the displayed profiles. The new task asks: which of the 12 displayed attributes does the response invoke, and how closely does the response's language match a level the respondent saw? The output is therefore $P(\text{attribute referenced} \mid \text{response, displayed profiles})$ rather than $P(\text{theory code} \mid \text{response})$.

The two classifications answer different questions. Theory-code classification asks what *kind* of reasoning a respondent used (civic, functional, identity, economic). Stimulus-correspondence classification asks which displayed *attribute* the response refers to and which level the response best matches. The first depends on a theory-derived codebook; the second depends only on the conjoint stimuli, which makes it portable to other conjoint experiments without translating their attributes into a theory-specific codebook.

D.2 Profile-context reconstruction

The naturalization survey asks the open-text question after a specific paired-choice task (the wording is "Why did you choose this person as more deserving of citizenship?"). In the South Korea instrument, the open-text item (Q129) follows the eighth of ten paired choices (Choice_8 = Q123); in Taiwan, the open-text item (Q89) follows the seventh and final choice (Choice_7 = Q88). For each respondent, I reconstruct the selected and unselected profile shown for that target task by reshaping the long-format conjoint data on `question_profile` = "8.1"/"8.2" for South Korea and "7.1"/"7.2" for Taiwan, retaining all 12 attribute levels for each profile. When the social integration cue was withheld from a respondent (`cue_shown` $= 0$), the social-integration field is removed from both profiles in the prompt context. The classifier is given the open-text response together with this two-profile context and produces a JSON object with the fields described in Table D.1.

Field	Values
mentioned_attributes	List of any of the 12 displayed attributes invoked, or [``none'']
primary_attribute	Single attribute, or multiple, general_profile, none
primary_profile	selected, unselected, both, unclear, none
matched_level	Level text from a profile, or empty when match is below generic
match_strength	exact, near, generic, construct_only, none
selection_relevance	supports_selected, rejects_unselected, compares_profiles, general_reason, none
confidence	HIGH, MEDIUM, LOW
reasoning	Free-text rationale

Table D.1: Stimulus-correspondence coding schema.

D.3 Models and agreement

Two models classify all 4,049 responses against the displayed profiles: GPT-4o-mini (closed-weight, primary classifier) and Qwen 2.5 32B (open-weight, robustness anchor). Both run with temperature $= 0$ and seed $= 42$. Token-level log-probabilities for the `primary_attribute` value are extracted on the same basis as Appendix C. JSON parse rate is 100% on a 40-case pilot and remains $> 99.5\%$ on the full corpus after a single retry pass on transient API failures.

Cohen's κ between the two models on `primary_attribute` is 0.848 (raw agreement 86.3%, $N = 4{,}049$). This sits inside the range of the strongest pairs in the six-model panel reported in Appendix C (which spans 0.578–0.886, with the strongest being Qwen 32B–72B at 0.886). The substantive conclusions below hold under either model.

D.4 Cue effect on attribute uptake

Table D.2 reports the share of responses whose primary referent is the `social_integration` attribute, separately by country, model, and cue-shown status. The cue effect is large in both countries and almost identical across the two models. Bootstrap percentile 90% and 95% confidence intervals (2,000 iterations) lie far from zero.

Model	Country	Cue 0	Cue 1	Diff (pp)	90% CI
GPT-4o-mini	South Korea	1.20%	13.0%	+11.8	[9.9, 13.7]
GPT-4o-mini	Taiwan	1.05%	19.9%	+18.8	[16.5, 20.9]
Qwen 2.5 32B	South Korea	2.09%	14.0%	+11.9	[9.9, 13.8]
Qwen 2.5 32B	Taiwan	1.34%	21.9%	+20.6	[18.4, 22.7]

Table D.2: Cue effect on $P(\texttt{primary_attribute} = \texttt{social_integration})$. Bootstrap 90% CIs (2,000 iterations).

The cue also produces a *substitution* pattern at the attribute level, mirroring the substitution found in the theory-code LLM analysis and in the STM (main paper, Results). When the cue is shown, the share of responses primarily referencing language drops by 6.8 pp in South Korea and 4.3 pp in Taiwan, occupation drops by 2.0/2.8 pp, residence-length drops by 0.7/2.5 pp, and work-history drops by 1.7/2.3 pp. Identity attributes (ethnicity, religion, origin) move only a little. Figure D.1 plots the full attribute-mention rates, which include both primary and secondary mentions.

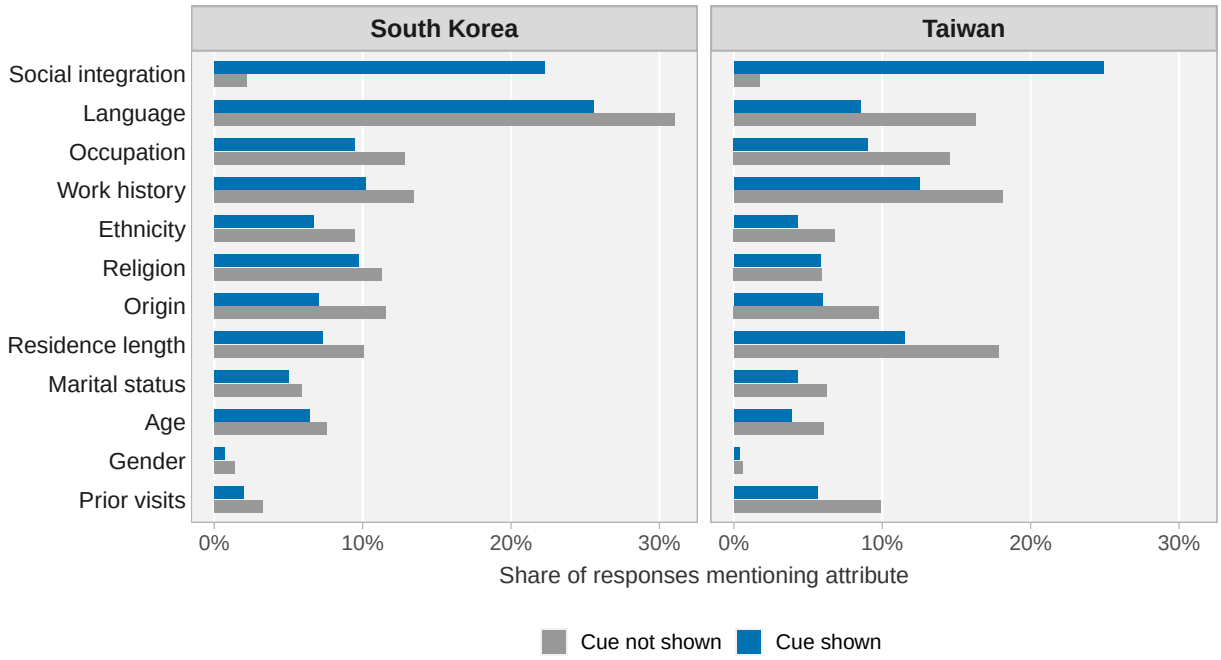

Figure D.1: Attribute mention rates by cue-shown status (GPT-4o-mini). The social-integration share rises sharply with the cue; language, occupation, work-history, and residence-length shares fall.

D.5 Selected-profile match rate

Among responses that invoke any displayed attribute (i.e., `primary_profile` $\neq$ `none`), most refer to the profile the respondent selected rather than the unselected one. Table D.3 reports the share, separately by model, country, and cue-shown status. The rate sits in the high 70s to mid 80s and is flat across cue-shown conditions. The selected-profile share measures whether respondents justify their choice by features of their pick; the cue effect itself appears in the primary-attribute distribution above.

Model	**Country**	**Cue 0** (n)	**Cue 0 share**	**Cue 1** (n)	**Cue 1 share**
GPT-4o-mini	South Korea	881	80.1%	841	78.7%
GPT-4o-mini	Taiwan	873	72.9%	797	74.9%
Qwen 2.5 32B	South Korea	943	84.6%	911	84.5%
Qwen 2.5 32B	Taiwan	913	82.7%	857	82.6%

Table D.3: Share of responses with `primary_profile` = `selected` among responses that reference any displayed attribute.

D.6 Convergence with the theory-coded classification

Cross-tabulating the majority-vote theory code (Appendix C) against the GPT-4o-mini stimulus-correspondence `primary_attribute` confirms that the two classifications converge on the central mappings. Each row of Table D.4 shows the share of responses with that theory code that fall into each `primary_attribute`.

	soc_int.	language	occupation	work_hist.	religion	ethnicity	origin	resid._len.	other
civic_commitment	**0.57**	0.04	0.01	0.00	0.00	0.01	0.01	0.01	0.36
functional_integration	0.04	**0.34**	0.00	0.01	0.00	0.00	0.00	**0.19**	0.41
economic_focus	0.00	0.01	**0.29**	**0.30**	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.01	0.40
identity_concern	0.03	0.01	0.00	0.00	**0.29**	**0.19**	**0.18**	0.00	0.31
none_of_above	0.02	0.00	0.00	0.01	0.01	0.00	0.01	0.00	0.96

Table D.4: Theory code (rows) by primary stimulus attribute (columns), $N = 4{,}603$ (responses with both a majority-vote theory code and a GPT-4o-mini stimulus-correspondence label). Each row is a conditional distribution and sums to 1.0 (within rounding). Bold cells mark the largest single-attribute mapping per row. The `other` column aggregates `multiple`, `none`, `general_profile`, age, gender, married, and prior_visits. `civic_commitment` maps primarily to `social_integration`; `functional_integration` splits between language and residence-length; `economic_focus` splits between occupation and work-history; `identity_concern` splits among religion, ethnicity, and origin. `none_of_above` maps almost entirely to `other` (driven by `none`, ≈56%, and `general_profile`, ≈18%).

The "other" column aggregates seven secondary categories. For `civic_commitment`, the largest sub-category in this column is `multiple` (23% of `civic_commitment` cases), which means the response invoked social integration alongside another attribute. The stimulus-grounded coding therefore agrees with the theory code in the substantive sense for some of the cases where the strict primary-attribute label differs.

The crosstab also identifies a feature the theory codebook does not separate: `functional_integration` as a single code spans two distinct attribute uptakes (language at 34% and residence-length at 19%) that respondents experience as different stimuli on different profiles. The same applies to `identity_concern`, which the displayed-attribute coding splits among religion, ethnicity, and country of origin. Researchers can either treat these as one category, as the theory codebook does, or estimate separate cue effects on each, which the stimulus-correspondence framework permits without rewriting the theory codebook.

D.7 Match-strength distribution

The two models differ in how they distribute responses across match-strength levels. GPT-4o-mini is more concentrated at `exact` (52% of responses) with a smaller `near` share (10%), while Qwen 2.5 32B distributes more evenly across `exact`, `near`, and `generic` (28%, 27%, 23%). The two models nonetheless agree on the same primary-attribute label for 86% of responses, so the divergence sits inside the gradation rather than at the level of which attribute is referenced.

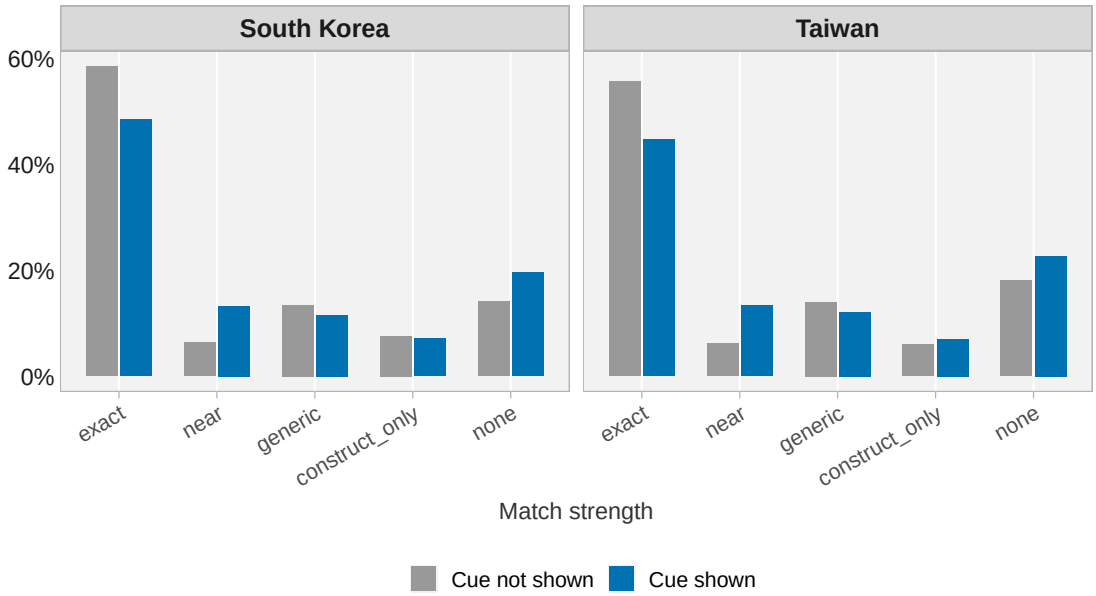

Figure D.2: Match-strength distribution by cue-shown status (GPT-4o-mini).

D.8 Caveat

The stimulus-correspondence measure is post-choice. What it captures is whether respondents anchor their justification to the displayed stimuli; whether those stimuli caused the choice is a separate question. A response that names the social-integration attribute after the fact is consistent with the cue having driven the selection, but it is also consistent with post-hoc rationalization or acquiescence to whatever the prior question emphasized. The same caveat applies to the theory-code classification in Appendix C and to the manipulation-check literature more broadly (Aronow et al., 2019; Ziegler, 2022). The contribution here is methodological rather than causal: it supplies a stimulus-grounded measure of attribute uptake to set alongside the theory-coded measure, with the two converging on the substantive conclusion.

E Framework Portability

The main analysis uses a conjoint design with within-design treatment randomization: the social integration attribute is randomly withheld, creating a clean cue-shown vs. cue-not-shown comparison that STM can incorporate as a prevalence covariate. Most conjoint experiments do not have this feature. To test whether the framework works in the more common setup, this appendix applies it to a standard conjoint on immigrant *admission* to South Korea (Denney & Green 2021), where all attributes are always shown and no within-design treatment randomization is available. The setup is lighter: LDA topic modeling (replicating the original analysis) and LLM classification with two models (GPT-4o-mini and Qwen 2.5 3B).

Denney & Green (2021) embedded open-text responses in a conjoint experiment examining South Korean attitudes toward immigrant admission ($N = 1{,}008$). Respondents evaluated paired immigrant profiles varying on seven attributes (reason for application, country of origin, language skills, profession, employment plans, gender, and ethnicity) and explained their choice in an open-text response.

The immigration attitudes literature identifies three competing explanations for how the public evaluates immigrants: sociotropic concerns (national-level norms and contribution), economic self-interest (labor market and fiscal concerns), and ethnocultural identity (origin-based preferences) (Hainmueller & Hopkins 2015). Applying the framework from the main analysis, the trichotomy is refined into five codes that distinguish functional integration (language ability, adaptation, settlement effort) from sociotropic reasoning.

Code	Definition
Sociotropic	Social harmony, community benefit, public safety, normative fit
Economic	Employment, labor market, fiscal concerns (personal or national)
Integration	Language ability, cultural adaptation, settlement effort
Identity	Ethnicity, national origin, gender, religion, co-ethnic preference
Other	Uninformative, vague impressions, refusals

Table E.1: Classification codes for the immigration admission conjoint.

Table E.2 shows the six LDA topics ($K = 6$) with revised labels informed by the five-code framework. Two topics capture functional integration (language acquisition and Korean fluency/adaptation, together 36% of documents), one captures identity (co-ethnic preference, 17%), one captures sociotropic

reasoning (societal benefit, 16%), one captures economic concerns (employment plans, 13%), and one is genuinely mixed (profession and nationality, 18%). LDA rather than STM is used because the original study did not include a treatment randomization amenable to prevalence covariates.

Topic	Label	Framework	Top terms (English gloss)	%
1	General Profile Evaluation	Mixed	occupation, immigration, ethnicity, nationality	18.0
2	Employment Plans & Purpose	Economic	job-seeking, activity, asylum, plan	13.4
3	Co-ethnic Preference	Identity	co-ethnic, employment, North Korea, person	16.8
4	Integration Effort	Integration	language, woman, settlement, effort	16.1
5	Societal Benefit	Sociotropic	Korea, country, help, society	15.8
6	Language & Employment	Integration	Korean (lang.), fluent, adaptation, ability	19.9

Table E.2: LDA topics ($K = 6$) with revised framework labels.

For LLM classification, GPT-4o-mini and Qwen 2.5 3B independently classify the 1,008 responses using the five-code codebook, achieving 79.2% agreement (Cohen's $\kappa = 0.737$). Cross-tabulating LDA topic assignments with LLM classifications shows convergence on the core constructs: for four of five non-mixed LDA topics, the dominant LLM code matches the expected framework label. Topic 2 (Employment) maps to economic, Topic 3 (Co-ethnic Preference) to identity, Topic 5 (Societal Benefit) to sociotropic, and Topic 6 (Language & Employment) to integration.

What Denney & Green (2021) described broadly as "sociotropic" reasoning decomposes into three distinct constructs (sociotropic, economic, and integration), each with a corresponding LDA topic. Functional integration emerges as the single largest category in both LDA (36% of documents) and LLM classification (20–27%), yet it was underspecified in the original analysis. Applying the framework retrospectively to existing data can sharpen constructs that were too coarse in the original study.

F Additional Robustness Analyses

F.1 Topic count selection diagnostics

Tables F.1 and F.2 report `searchK()` diagnostic metrics for the candidate topic counts evaluated in each country (ELBO = Evidence Lower Bound; higher is better). $K = 6$ was selected for South Korea based on the coherence-exclusivity balance: exclusivity is past the main elbow (9.36), semantic coherence is better than $K = 7$ or $K = 8$, and residuals are substantially lower than $K = 4$ or $K = 5$. $K = 9$ produced a degenerate solution (2 EM iterations) and was excluded. $K = 8$ was selected for Taiwan because it achieves the best semantic coherence (-228.5, the least negative across all K) while exclusivity (9.56) is well past the elbow, and residuals improve substantially from $K = 7$ (5.57) to $K = 8$ (5.08).

K	Exclusivity	Sem. Coherence	Held-Out Lik.	Residuals	ELBO
4	9.025	-257.8	-4.671	4.635	$-17{,}264$
5	9.275	-264.9	-4.625	4.521	$-17{,}266$
6	**9.362**	$\mathbf{-274.2}$	-4.626	**4.360**	$-17{,}204$
7	9.446	-278.3	-4.653	4.220	$-17{,}192$
8	9.483	-282.6	-4.550	3.866	$-17{,}103$
10	9.614	-281.4	-4.632	3.675	$-17{,}091$
12	9.661	-272.8	-4.597	4.054	$-17{,}055$

Table F.1: South Korea `searchK()` diagnostics ($K = 4$–12). $K = 9$ omitted (degenerate solution). Selected $K = 6$ (bold).

K	Exclusivity	Sem. Coherence	Held-Out Lik.	Residuals	ELBO
5	9.293	-230.0	-4.537	5.653	$-24{,}893$
6	9.474	-244.0	-4.450	5.629	$-24{,}617$
7	9.515	-242.2	-4.592	5.572	$-24{,}743$
8	**9.555**	$\mathbf{-228.5}$	-4.489	**5.084**	$-24{,}358$
9	9.613	-249.5	-4.460	5.011	$-24{,}347$
10	9.615	-256.1	-4.537	4.882	$-24{,}563$
12	9.701	-251.6	-4.421	5.431	$-24{,}312$
15	9.749	-277.1	-4.457	6.047	$-24{,}094$

Table F.2: Taiwan `searchK()` diagnostics ($K = 5$–15). Selected $K = 8$ (bold).

F.2 Majority-vote threshold sensitivity

Table F.3 shows the civic commitment treatment effect under alternative majority-vote thresholds. Effects are stable across thresholds (14.3–15.3 pp in South Korea, 17.5–18.2 pp in Taiwan). Exclusions are balanced across treatment conditions at all thresholds (all χ^2 $p > 0.20$). Dropping GPT-4o-mini entirely and using a 3-of-5 open-weight majority produces near-identical estimates.

Threshold	Country	No Cue (%)	Cue (%)	Effect (pp)	N incl.
3/6 ($\geq$3)	South Korea	3.8	18.1	$+14.3$	2,007
3/6 ($\geq$3)	Taiwan	1.8	19.7	$+17.9$	2,015
4/6 ($\geq$4)	South Korea	2.0	16.7	$+14.7$	1,820
4/6 ($\geq$4)	Taiwan	1.0	19.2	$+18.2$	1,935
5/6 ($\geq$5)	South Korea	1.0	16.3	$+15.3$	1,569
5/6 ($\geq$5)	Taiwan	0.6	18.3	$+17.7$	1,693
3/5 no GPT	South Korea	2.6	16.8	$+14.3$	1,953
3/5 no GPT	Taiwan	1.3	18.8	$+17.5$	1,991

Table F.3: Civic commitment treatment effect under alternative majority-vote thresholds. The "3/5 no GPT" row excludes GPT-4o-mini and uses a 3-of-5 open-weight majority. Exclusions are balanced across treatment conditions at all thresholds.

F.3 Keyword baseline comparison

To contextualize the LLM contribution, a simple keyword/dictionary classifier was applied to all 4,049 responses. The dictionary maps Korean and Chinese keywords to the five classification codes (e.g., □□/□□ → civic_commitment; □□/□□ → economic_focus; □□□/□□ → functional_integration; □□/□□ → identity_concern). Responses matching no keywords are classified as "other."

When a response matches keywords from multiple categories, the first match in code priority order (civic, functional, identity, economic) is assigned. The keyword classifier achieves 62% agreement with the LLM majority vote (Cohen's $\kappa = 0.51$, moderate). The main limitation is coverage: 51% of responses receive no keyword match and default to "other," compared to 21% for the LLM. The keyword baseline detects the civic commitment treatment effect in the correct direction ($+5.9$ pp in South Korea, $+7.6$ pp in Taiwan) but substantially attenuates the magnitude relative to the LLM ($+14.7$ and $+18.2$ pp). The LLM gains the most ground over keyword matching on short, semantically ambiguous responses,

where context and world knowledge compensate for the absence of explicit keywords.

F.4 Treatment effects by response length

Table F.4 reports the civic commitment treatment effect separately for short ($\leq$ 7 characters, below the corpus median) and long ($\geq$ 8 characters) responses. The treatment effect is present and directionally consistent across all length groups but is substantially larger for longer responses. Even responses of five characters or fewer show a +7 pp civic commitment shift, confirming that the treatment effect is not an artifact of long, elaborated responses.

Country	Length	No Cue (%)	Cue (%)	Effect (pp)	N
South Korea	Long ($\geq$8 chars)	3.1	21.5	+18.4	1,099
South Korea	Short ($\leq$7 chars)	0.3	9.3	+9.0	718
Taiwan	Long ($\geq$8 chars)	2.6	34.4	+31.8	703
Taiwan	Short ($\leq$7 chars)	0.2	9.9	+9.7	1,235

Table F.4: Civic commitment treatment effect by response length (median split at 7 characters). Effects are present in both length groups but larger for longer responses, consistent with longer responses providing more classifiable signal.

F.5 Prompt templates

The system prompt is identical across all six classifiers and is generated from the YAML codebook. It consists of four sections: (1) task framing and instructions for handling short responses and the language/residence boundary; (2) five classification codes with definitions, inclusion criteria, and exclusion criteria; (3) 25 labeled few-shot examples in Korean and Traditional Chinese; and (4) nine classification rules and the JSON output format.

The prompt opens with task framing:

> "You are a research assistant coding open-ended survey responses about attitudes toward immigrant naturalization in Taiwan and South Korea. [...] Your task is to classify each response."

Two task-specific instructions follow. First, short responses (1–3 words) must be classified if they contain any substantive content; brevity alone is never a reason for the residual code. Second, standalone mentions of language ability or residence duration map to `functional_integration` rather than

`civic_commitment`, unless explicitly framed with civic engagement language. The five code definitions (with inclusion/exclusion criteria) and 25 labeled few-shot examples in Korean and Traditional Chinese follow, along with nine numbered classification rules and the JSON output format. The full 168-line prompt is reproduced in the replication archive at `output/classification/system_prompt.txt`.

The user message differs between classifiers. For GPT-4o-mini, the user message is: "Classify this survey response: [text]." For the open-weight models via Ollama, the user message adds an explicit enumeration of valid codes and a JSON output format reminder: "The 'code' MUST be exactly one of: civic_commitment, functional_integration, identity_concern, economic_focus, none_of_above. Respond with ONLY a JSON object." The additional constraint reduces parse errors for smaller models that occasionally invent code names or wrap JSON in markdown.

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